

THE
PURPLE
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BY JEFFREY J. SMITH

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THIS PHASE WAS RELEASED DECEMBER 21, 2025. IT TOOK SIX MONTHS TO MAKE. THE FIRST 87 PAGES WERE COMPLETED IN THE FIVE MONTHS IMMEDIATELY FOLLOWING THE RELEASE OF PHASE 2, & THE LAST MEATLESS FLOPPY LITTLE CHUNKS WERE WRAPPED UP NICE IN THE LAST WEEK OF NOVEMBER & THE FIRST TWO WEEKS OF DECEMBER. STAND OR BE BERTEN, BOW OR BE BERTEN, WHATEVER, WHATEVER, WHAT. EVER. WE WERE (ARE!) PRIVILEGED TO SUFFER AND YOU LOSERS WERE (WILL BE!) PRIVILEGED TO WAIT. BECAUSE THAT'S HOW THIS WORKS, OBVIOUSLY. WHAT YOU'RE MISSING IS ADVERSARY, AND I WANT TO PROVIDE FOR YOU LIKE I ALWAYS HAVE, BUT IT REALLY TICKS ME OFF WHEN YOU WON'T EAT YOUR GREENS! PROMISE AT LEAST TO TAKE ME SERIOUSLY IN EXCHANGE FOR THE FAVORZ AS A GESTURE OF MY KIND INTENTIONS, HERE'S A GOOD ONE FOR YOU— TWO BODIES WALKED MILES & MILES ALONG A MISERABLE WET HOT STRETCH OF MIDWESTERN HIGHWAY TO MAKE A PHONE CALL. THEY PASS TREES, OPEN MOUNTAINS, CAROLINA LOCUSTS, MORE TREES. THEY FINALLY GET TO THE PHONE BOOTH, REJOICE, PICK UP THE RECEIVER — — — DEAD! YOU & I HANG UP ON THEM.

SPECIAL THANKS TO CHARLIE, HERBERT, CARTER, & JACK FOR ALL OF YOUR PATIENCE & ENTHUSIASM. LOVE YOU ALL FOREVER, NEEDLESS TO SAY. HARD-BOILED PRO-LANDE ART CRIT WAS PROVIDED PRE-RELEASE BY THE GREEN NINJA — THANKS. I THINK PEPAYK MIGHT HAVE READ THIS ONE? HI PEPAYK. I AM GOING TO BRING CANNISTERS OF FRESH EXPENSIVE SPICES TO THE CUPCAKE OK THEY WERE SPOKEN. WE CAN LEARN ABOUT COVES IN KETCHUP CAKE.

BONUS HUGE DELUXE SUPERSIZE THANKS IS HERE FOR YOU — IF YOU ARE CHARLIE, WHO HELPED OUT SO MUCH W/ VISUALS ON PAGES, CHARLIE, & REFINED CRITIQUE. YOU TRULY ARE DA DAWG. Quid AND ANOTHER, STILL, IF YOU ARE THE BRAVE & NOBLE CHAMPION HORSIE! THANK YOU FOR BEING MY FRIEND, GOD WILLING WE WILL FROLIC IN THE RAIN OR SOMETHING SOON OK.



NEIN SET

LOVE DOESN'T REIN TO COVER
WAVESTO OF A HAIL



Lynn is looking more
trepidatious by the time
they arrive at Markus'.

He's tapping the wheel
and jiggling his leg.

When he stops the car, he turns
to look out both front
side windows.

Cam watches him crane his neck with little concern.

"I'm going to have to go around back. There's some cords and shit we'll need."

He pulls on the car door handle, popping it without letting it swing open.
Lynn nods hesitantly.

"What are we going to need them for?"

"Opening the traps."

"Isn't that - won't animal control do that, if we-"

"You trust these people to be able to do that?"

Cam looks mildly disgusted.

"We'll be lucky if anyone actually shows up. If I called 911 right now, you think an ambulance is coming? Get real. But you wanted to do it, so let's do it."

He opens the door and makes to leave, still talking as Lynn opens his mouth to voice opposition.

"Can you go inside, though?"

He usually leaves the front door unlocked. I think I left my inhaler in there."

"Your-"

"I'm pretty sure it's in the dresser by the TV," Cam says, standing up and looking back at Lynn over his shoulder.

"Probably the top drawer. I won't be long, just come around the back when you get it."

Seeing Lynn's expression, he lingers by the car. The air outside is frigid.

"He's gone. He's definitely gone, okay. Look, his truck's gone. He's at work, you're not going to run into him. You're fine."



He slams the door without waiting for a response. Lynn watches as he stalks off behind the house. His gait is incredibly lumbering for someone so small.

Lynn was not previously aware that there was a shed on the property at all. He's only been inside Markus' house once, and it hadn't gone well. He'd expected as much, at the time, but the circumstances of the encounter had been unusual.

Cam had called, late, from Markus' home phone and left several voicemails of increasing bizarreness and apparent urgency, insisting on being picked up early.

It doesn't matter where you'd take him, he'd insisted. Just swing by.

You can drop him off anywhere, he doesn't care, he knows you've never got any plans on Friday nights.

There had been something frightening in those messages. Lynn had even considered calling Lori to let her know before he left.

He'd made the drive in the dark, and when he got to the house Cam had ushered him almost wordlessly through the living room, and into the kitchen, where Markus had been.

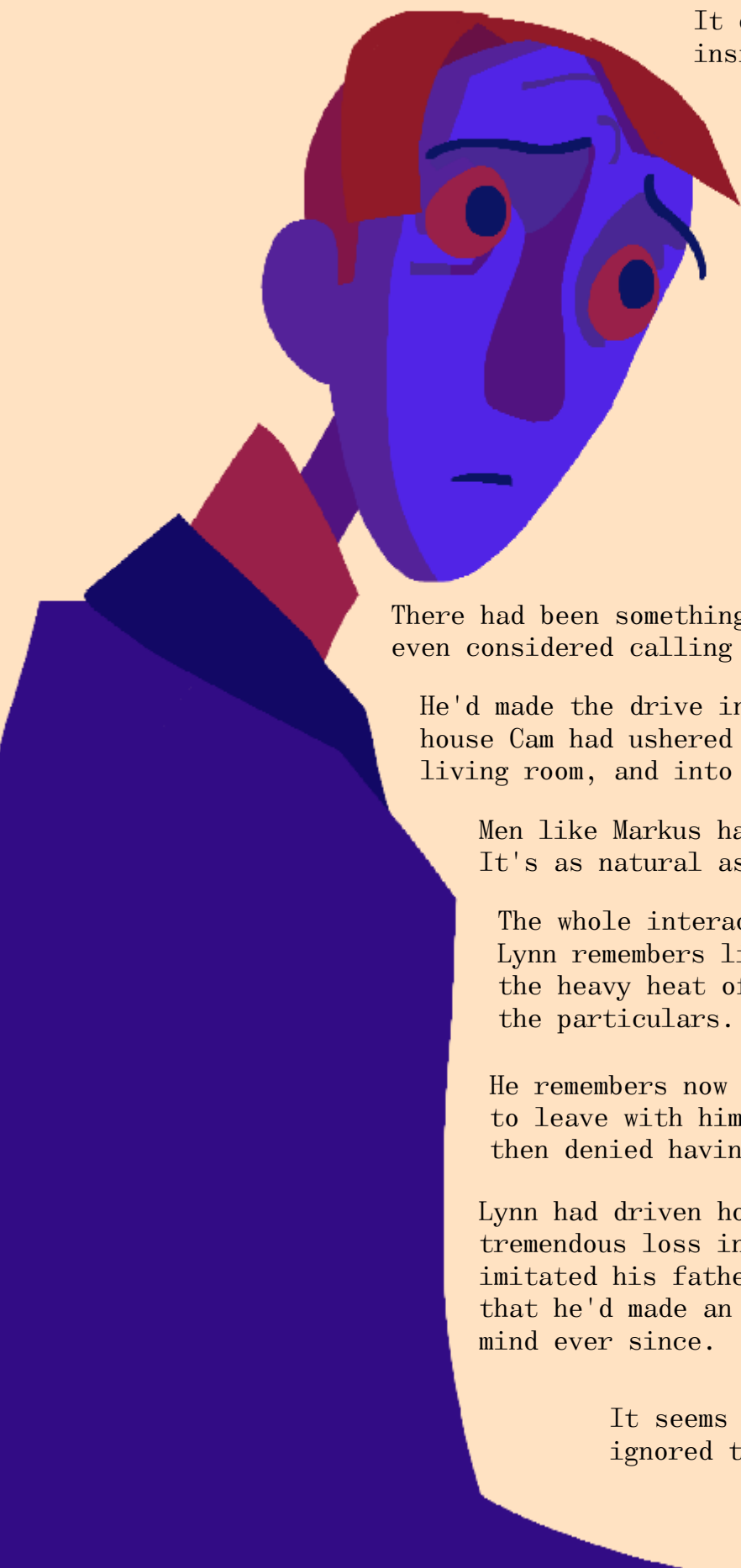
Men like Markus have an innate dislike of men like Lynn. It's as natural as anything.

The whole interaction had been nightmarish. Lynn remembers little of what any of them talked about; the heavy heat of embarrassment has since drowned out all the particulars.

He remembers now only that when he'd asked Cam to leave with him, Cam had first resisted, and then denied having called Lynn at all.

Lynn had driven home alone. There was tremendous loss in seeing the ways Cam imitated his father's vapid cruelties, one that he'd made an effort to put out of his mind ever since.

It seems stupid now to have ignored the obvious for so long.





He would not have come back here if he'd known he would have to go into the house alone, but it's too late now.

Out of the car and up the steps of the porch,
and the front door is unlocked,
as Cam said it would be.

There is nothing encouraging about that.

The TV is still on inside, the volume as loud as Cam left it. Nothing moves in the living room that Lynn can see from here.

He can't actually smell the house from outside, but he can imagine it. The memory of intimate filth is as fresh to him as ever.

It's musty and oppressive. The living room isn't big; it feels smaller still in the stench. Mold in the carpet, on the ceiling, on the food sitting out.

The heavy funk of a rot presently unfolding.



Lynn holds his breath at first as he closes the door, exhaling slowly through his nose as he crosses the living room. His gaze cycles rapidly between the floor and what's in front of him as he tries to avoid stepping on anything that will make noise or stick to his shoes.

He's gritting his teeth by the time he gets to the dresser. More than a smell, it is a miasma. The air is thick; it bends and gives in his lungs like pudding from a cup. He breathes through his nose in spite of it. The taste of it, he's sure, will leave a physical residue in his mouth.

Sweat beads on the creases of his forehead in spite of the chill lingering from outside. He opens the top drawer.

in tragedy
he high-speed train
ded Wednesday derailed and
shed into a bridge about 85
south of Hamburg. The
act hurled Hawk through a
dome.
It was supposed to be the last
ch on the Lurail pass. Hawk's
son, U.S. Army Maj. Rob
type, said Saturday.
The crash's death toll has
ched 102. Rescuers continued
search for bodies by hand
aturday, while investigators tried
determine what made a wheel
the first passenger car break.

There had been
no officials said
anyone) Tan
were killed
lay laid 72 people
spalized leaving
the
the engine for
the shops for
when it crashed
ning, airborne
all of the land
a field
men repeatedly
from Korea.

who was deaf and had a
retrial party, died Oct. 14, 1984.
Police say she was beaten
her boyfriend while she
mother went to pick up her son, child, at
school. The next day she was rushed to
stopped breathing and died in Novem-
ber 1985, charges of first-degree mur-
der and child abuse against
were dropped after defense
experts argued that she could
have died from her mother's attempts to
revive her after she stopped breathing.
The case remains under investigation
and charges could be refied if other
evidence surfaces, according to the
Maricopa County Attorney's Office.
Neither Samantha nor her family was
known to CPS.

It takes a moment make out the disjointed
mass of shapes.

In the shifting light of the TV,
the arrangement comes together.



It's especially easy because it's all familiar.

Lively, casual clutter lines the drawer; a neat little bundle of cords on top
of a notebook, a tin full of guitar picks. Cam's inhaler is at the front of
the drawer, and Lynn hardly notices.

His hand shakes as he opens the drawer further, suddenly urgent.

Towards the back, underneath the notebook, there's a clump of
magazine clippings. He doesn't need to look, but he does.

The headlines are unilaterally grim.



Abrupt organ failure, unforeseen cancers and rare gene conditions, actors falling to their deaths and dying of overdose.

Accidents on the road and in the workplace that left their survivors in pieces.

Lynn knows them all by heart.

His face is blotchy from his cheekbones to the backs of his ears. Getting found out never stops being humiliating. He stuffs the clippings into the inside pocket of his jacket with the quiet urgency of the embarrassed.

All at once he remembers where he is, and, looking back in the drawer, sees the inhaler. It's attached to a spacer much too small for Cam now.

He picks it up and turns it over uncomprehendingly. There's a chipped illustration of a bear demonstrating how to properly hold it flush to a child's face. The canister, too, is outdated.

Lynn pales, looking from the inhaler to the contents of the drawer and back. His breath hitches in his chest, and he puts together the only reasonable explanation for how these things got to Markus' house. To this drawer, in this arrangement.



Cam has always been hard to read. But it isn't difficult to put together what he must mean by this. It's incredibly straightforward, even to Lynn.

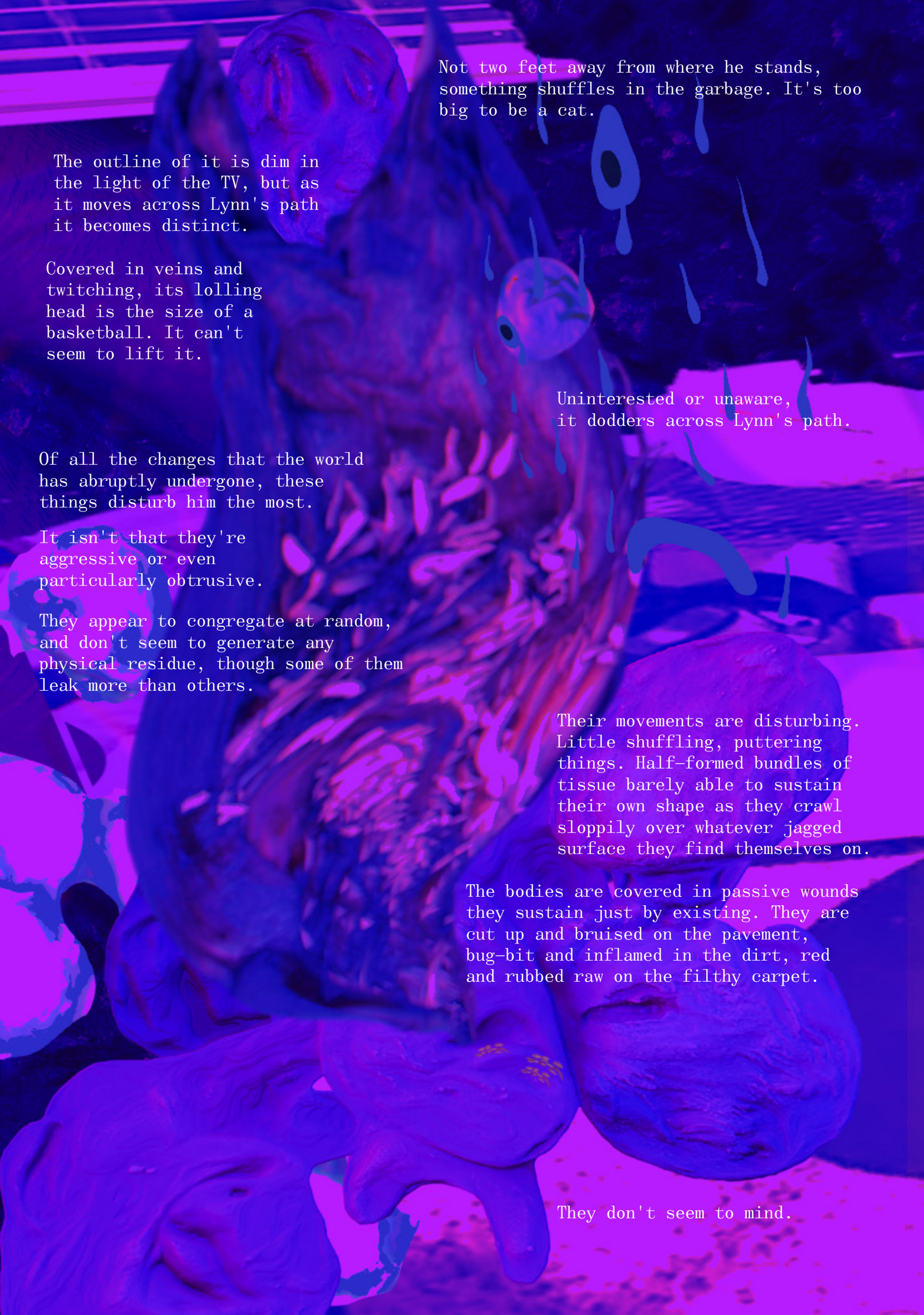
Taken by urgency, he slams the drawer shut and makes for the front door, but thinks better of it a few steps across the living room.

Cam is expecting him to come out onto the porch. He's almost definitely done retrieving whatever it was he needed from the shed, if he'd actually even needed anything. There is no reason for him not to be out front already, waiting for Lynn.

It's been years since they were close, but Cam has always loved to test boundaries. This won't end with the drawer; in retrospect, it seems unlikely that the drawer was even the beginning.

There's some vague new guilt tugging at his sleeve as he hesitates. It feels wrong, in some way, not to leave out the front door. To avoid whatever Cam has in store for him.

It feels like it would be cheating him out of something.



Not two feet away from where he stands,
something shuffles in the garbage. It's too
big to be a cat.

The outline of it is dim in
the light of the TV, but as
it moves across Lynn's path
it becomes distinct.

Covered in veins and
twitching, its lolling
head is the size of a
basketball. It can't
seem to lift it.

Of all the changes that the world
has abruptly undergone, these
things disturb him the most.

It isn't that they're
aggressive or even
particularly obtrusive.

They appear to congregate at random,
and don't seem to generate any
physical residue, though some of them
leak more than others.

Uninterested or unaware,
it dodders across Lynn's path.

Their movements are disturbing.
Little shuffling, puttering
things. Half-formed bundles of
tissue barely able to sustain
their own shape as they crawl
sloppily over whatever jagged
surface they find themselves on.

The bodies are covered in passive wounds
they sustain just by existing. They are
cut up and bruised on the pavement,
bug-bit and inflamed in the dirt, red
and rubbed raw on the filthy carpet.

They don't seem to mind.

There tends to be a smell, too, Lynn has noticed, when there's lots of them. It's organic, sweet and slightly fungal. It isn't unpleasant.

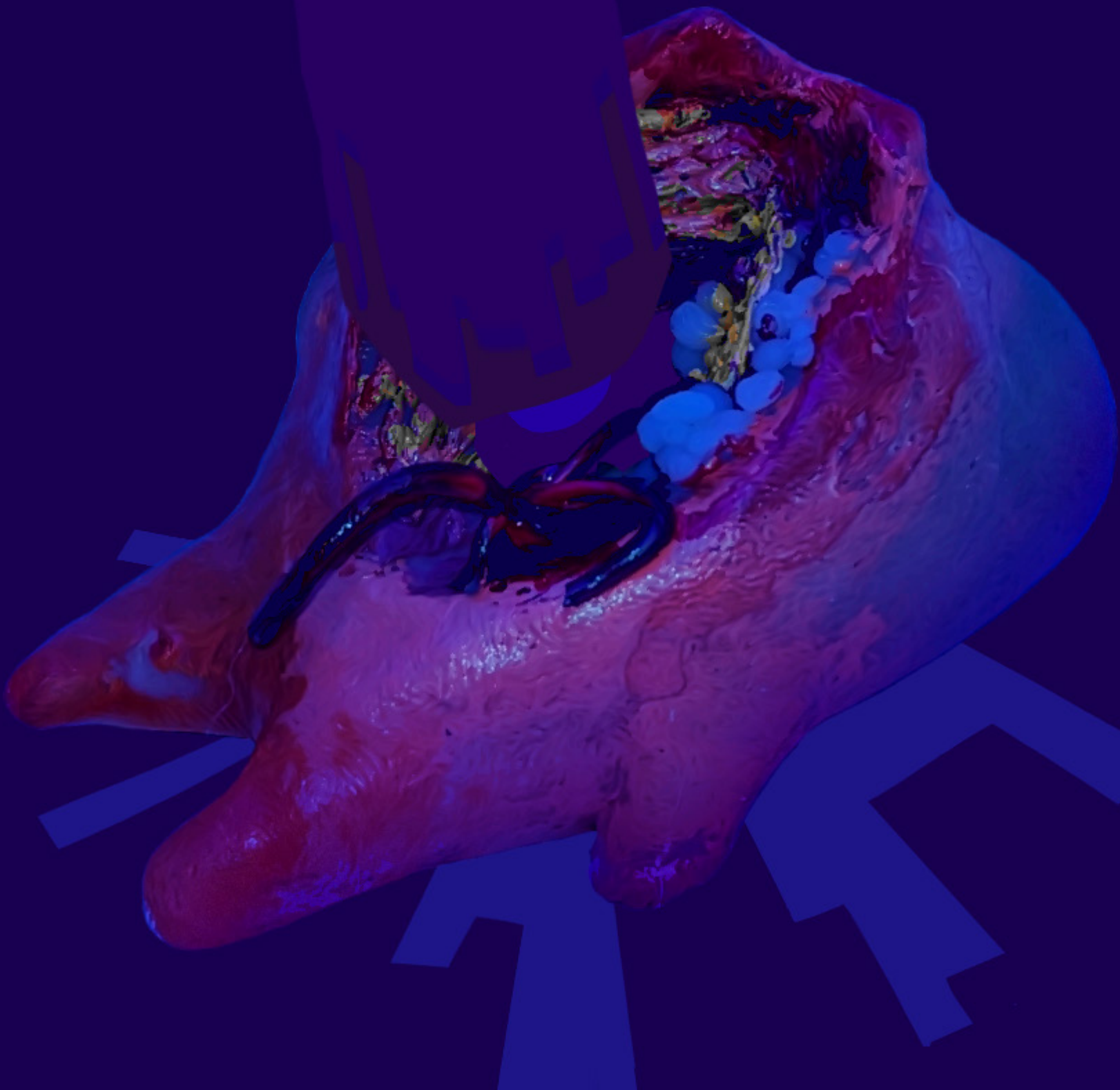
Something is terrible and familiar about that smell in equal measure. It's never strong, no matter how impressively the things are gathered, but it's potent in its faintness. The smell of small warm bodies in close proximity.

Lynn won't think about where he remembers it from.

Lynn lunges forward to the door and almost slips on something wet, scrambling comically in place to keep his footing.



When he sees the soft little skull he's ankle-deep in,
he sobs aloud.



Whipping around, Lynn dislodges his foot and flees down the hallway to the back of the house.

Perhaps deterred by the lack of light, the little masses do not seem to have ventured to the back of the house.



Lynn doesn't stop running until he's out of breath, several feet away from the end of the hallway.

When he tries to compare his memory of the place to the impressive distance between the living room and where he stands, he can't identify any reasonable cause for dissonance.

Slouched over with his hands above his knees he stands, panting, at the back of the house.

Eyes on the floor, his feet are dark shapes against stained beige carpeting, slowly coming into more detail as his vision adjusts to the dimness.

His left shoe and pant leg are spattered with dark fluid. He presses his lips together and averts his gaze.

The floor in front of the back door is covered in trash. Not food wrappers or cigarette butts, but true debris, the kind that's generally left out for bulk pickup. Most notably, an aging twin mattress is propped up vertically against it. The thing is so drastically discolored that it's visible even in the poorly lit

There's a side room directly to the right. There's no door in the frame, and when Lynn leans over the garbage to look into it he can smell the mattress, now only inches from his face.



It is uniquely rank amid the general foulness. It's a hot, overwhelming reek, intimately organic; a body smell. Excretions soaked into polyester and left to dry. Lynn can't imagine how foul this house was in its heyday, back when things like this mattress were fresh.

When he was younger, Lori had talked to him a few times about what it had been like here before she left.

She'd never been one to exaggerate, so her stories had left an impression.

At the time, Cam had only just moved in, and Lynn in particular was having trouble adjusting to the shift.

Cam had been five years old, and a completely animal presence. He hid constantly. Small for his age, he could tuck himself away in cabinets, under sinks, and beneath couches. He was always difficult to find, largely because he never stayed in one place for long. After a time in one hiding place, he would creep out when the room was empty to find a new one.

He walked quietly, sticking close to the edges of rooms. If he caught someone watching him, he would freeze, staring them down until they looked away or left.

Nearly impossible to contain, he found his way around any childproof lock placed low enough for him to reach. Most frequently, he stole food.

On two separate occasions, he'd stood in front of the fridge and ingested enough at such speed that he'd vomited where he stood before continuing to eat.

Standing at the end of the hallway in front of a blocked door, Lynn tries now to rationalize his own actions.

The contents of the drawer had been placed so deliberately that it could only have been a message, one Lynn receives now for a second time, reflecting on it in the hallway. His stomach drops out; the thought is as physical in him as undertow.

He wants to go back to the living room and look again, but he's only getting more worked up thinking about it. He sweats and shifts in place, bending his knees rhythmically in attempt to steady himself.

He's becoming increasingly certain that he can't leave the way he came in. He doesn't want to know what Cam has waiting for him.



There's no reason for this to be happening now.
This is no anniversary, there has been no upheave
to bring about a renewal of memory.

All this time, in spite of his own doubts, Lynn has clung hopefully
to the forgetfulness that has come to seem so innate in Cam.

Something comes crashing down in the living room.

It's unbearably loud. Lynn ducks
reflexively, almost dropping to his
knees. His hands cover his head,
shaking faintly against his temples.

The sound of breakage is
prolonged and shattering,
like whatever had collapsed
had been partly glass.

There's a guttural sound from somewhere around the living room, but Lynn's
staring, wide-eyed in the dark, and he doesn't see anything.

He freezes in place and waits.

The groaning continues, loud enough to be heard over the TV and mounting.

It sounds almost like water chugging down a drain. Droning and animal, without a trace of words in the body of it.

There's the sound of more little things breaking, crunching, being stepped on, as Markus, or something like him, enters the living room.

He lurches in from the kitchen, so big that Lynn thinks for a second he must be two or even three men moving as one. He's still groaning, dragging his feet as he moves.

Something he broke must be stuck in him, and the sounds of broken glass contending with itself persist until he reaches the carpeting.

Lynn remains frozen in place in the hallway, hunched over and horrified.

He's barely cognizant,
holding his breath,
waiting to be noticed.





Markus sits in front of the TV, his shoulders spanning two thirds of the couch.

He stares, rote, at the tiny screen several feet ahead of him.

Fully present in the moment, crouched now by the corner of the hallway, next to the mattress, Lynn can't wrap his head around what's in front of him.

The volume of the TV seems unbearably loud now, grating against Markus' steady oration.

Sensation seeps back into him. His knees are shaking, his eyes are dry; he hasn't blinked since he heard the crash.

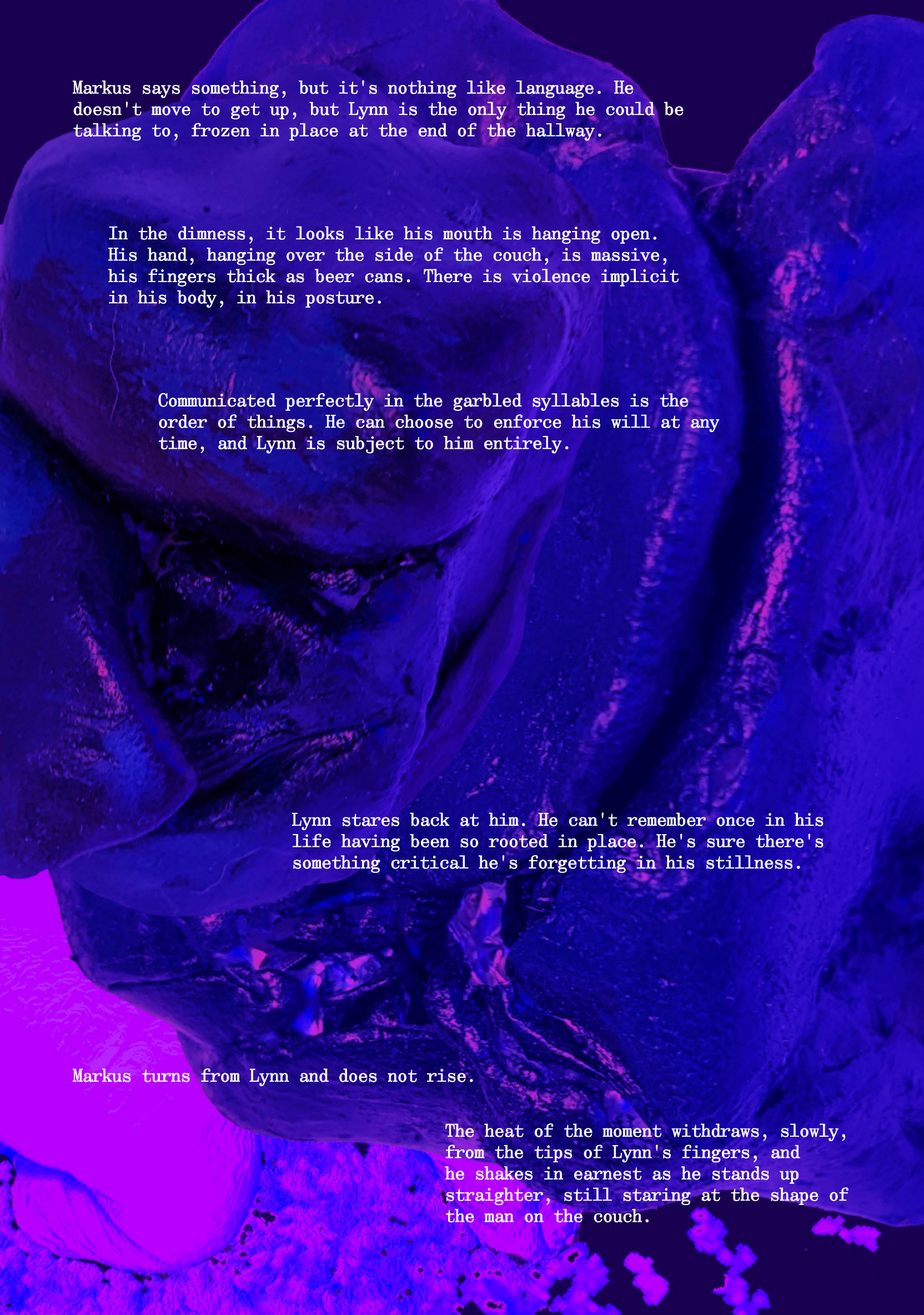
The first trickles of pain make their way up his back as he remains locked in a half-upright position.

There is a pressure building in his head that is here and not-here. He is too scared to be afraid.

Markus' head turns toward him.

The whites of Lynn's eyes are vivid, twin perfect exclamations in the dark of the hallway.





Markus says something, but it's nothing like language. He doesn't move to get up, but Lynn is the only thing he could be talking to, frozen in place at the end of the hallway.

In the dimness, it looks like his mouth is hanging open. His hand, hanging over the side of the couch, is massive, his fingers thick as beer cans. There is violence implicit in his body, in his posture.

Communicated perfectly in the garbled syllables is the order of things. He can choose to enforce his will at any time, and Lynn is subject to him entirely.

Lynn stares back at him. He can't remember once in his life having been so rooted in place. He's sure there's something critical he's forgetting in his stillness.

Markus turns from Lynn and does not rise.

The heat of the moment withdraws, slowly, from the tips of Lynn's fingers, and he shakes in earnest as he stands up straighter, still staring at the shape of the man on the couch.

It feels safer than looking away, like if he looks hard enough and pays enough attention, he'll be able to see what Markus is going to do before he actually does it.

But seeing at all is difficult, and the shadowy shapes of the hallway have gravity of their own, pulling Lynn's eyes into their orbit.

Something in the frame of the doorway next to him shifts. He's too tense to even flinch.

He holds his breath right where it's at for a moment, before, in a moment of characteristically forward desperation, he asks:

"Cam?"



Lynn does not so much as chance a look over his shoulder at the thing.

He scrambles to his feet, sprints back down the hallway towards the living room where Markus sits, motionless. The front door is still surrounded by squirming little wet things.

This is no means of escape. Cam is waiting for him.

Barreling instead through the kitchen, he leaps over the topped fridge and slips on wet broken glass piled up opposite it.

He drops again, gritty shards burying themselves in his palms, digging through his dress pants and into the thin meat of his knees.

The pain has no time to register.

The door to the garage is open and Lynn throws himself through it.





He fumbles at the concrete wall for a switch momentarily before coming to his senses and rushing for the manual release cord hanging from the ceiling.

The kitchen door swings open just as he pulls it, and his pursuer closes the distance between them without effort.

His hands drop to his sides, and hers strain, pressing down on a lump of bone on the back of her head, sinking some simplistic biological lever. Her jaw lowers in time with it.

She twists in place, working against herself. Sounds bubble out of her mouth in spurts as the hinge opens and shuts in time with the motion of her hands. Her arms are wobbling, meatless things, struggling to keep the lever down.

Lynn backs up a few tremulous steps, staring down the great pulsing column of her face. He's started crying, thick mucus-dense tears streaking down his face, mixing with sweat. He shakes his head.

"I'm sorry," he wheezes. "I'm so, I'm sorry, but I didn't—"



The lever snaps into place.

Her jaw tears open all the way, bone grinding
against itself so loud it could have been metal.

Shrieking and eruptive and newly undampened by makeshift lips,
her voice is paralytically high. In the endless, monosyllabic shriek,
Lynn knows what she's saying.

She lowers her head and swings it at him like a cudgel, striking
him in the side, still wailing. Lynn stumbles sideways, dropping
to one knee and raising his hands shakily, palms facing her.

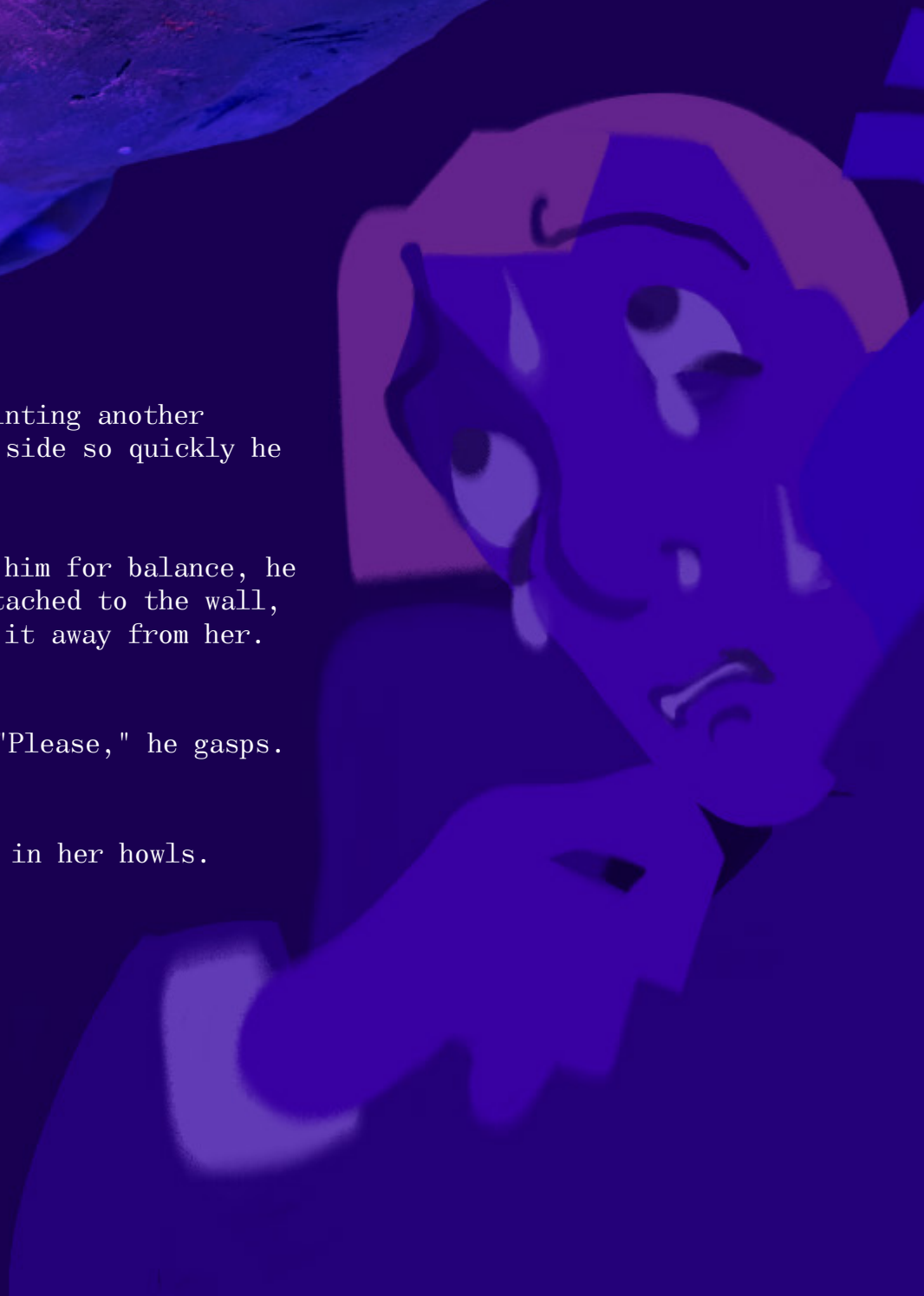


She bucks at him again, feinting another swing, and he ducks to the side so quickly he almost falls over.

Arms swinging behind him for balance, he grips a metal bar attached to the wall, leaning back against it away from her.

"Please," he gasps.

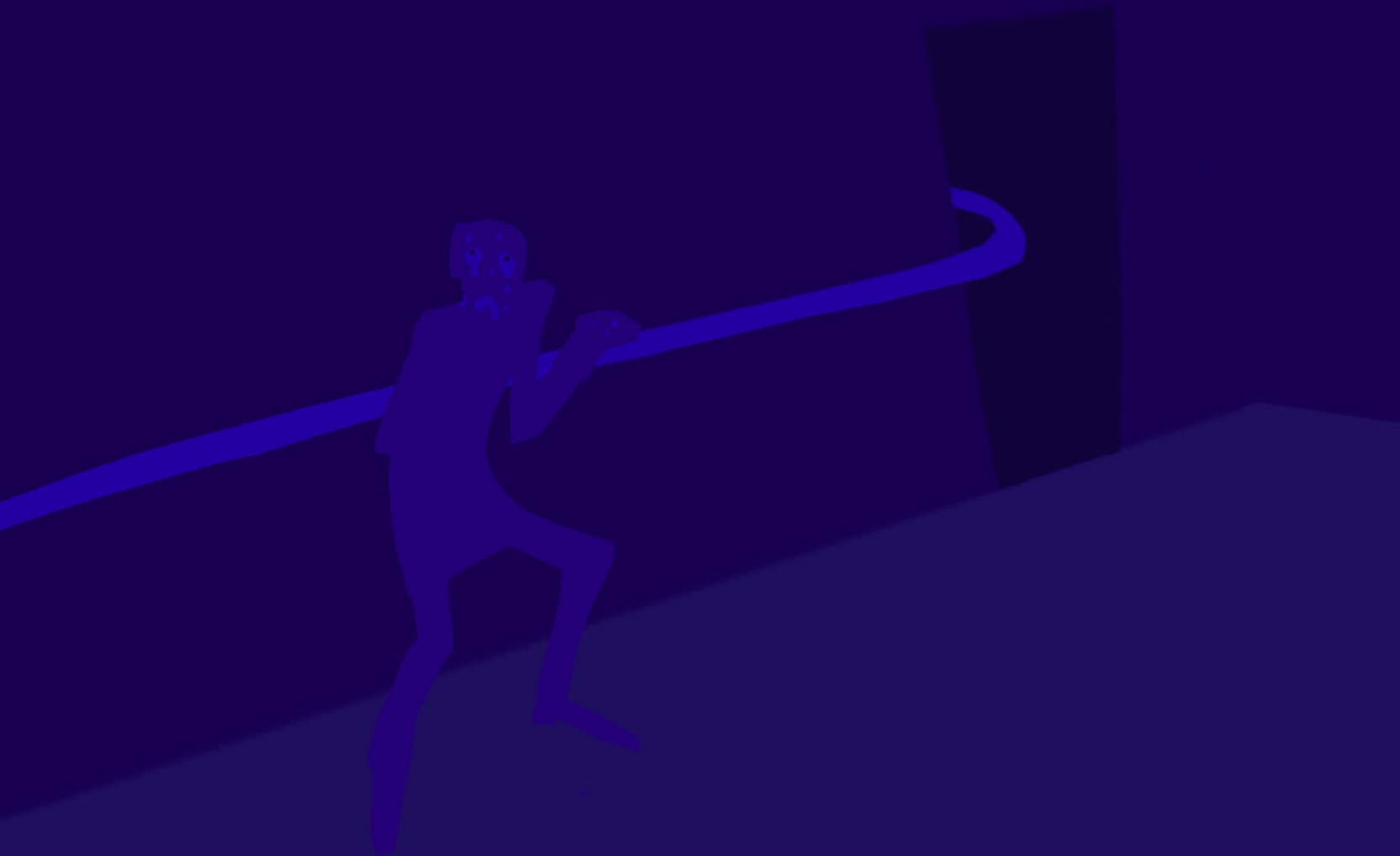
His voice is swallowed up in her howls.



The weight of her colossal skull is too much for her to hold up, and her neck buckles as she limps towards him. The front of her face drags on the ground between her legs, snoutlike.

Lynn inches to the side, still gripping the metal bar shakily. It curves behind him as he walks, and the concrete wall of the garage gives way to thin air.

He steps back into the newly formed space without thinking, gaze locked on his approaching mother.



His heel strikes concrete, and he chances a look over his shoulder.

It's nothing he hasn't seen before.



Wobbling backwards up the stairs, he watches the strength in the thing's arms fade. The lever in its head presses back up against its hands, and its cries are muffled intermittently as its jaw swings open and shut.

It can't seem to do anything else with its hands.
There's something deeply pitiable about that.

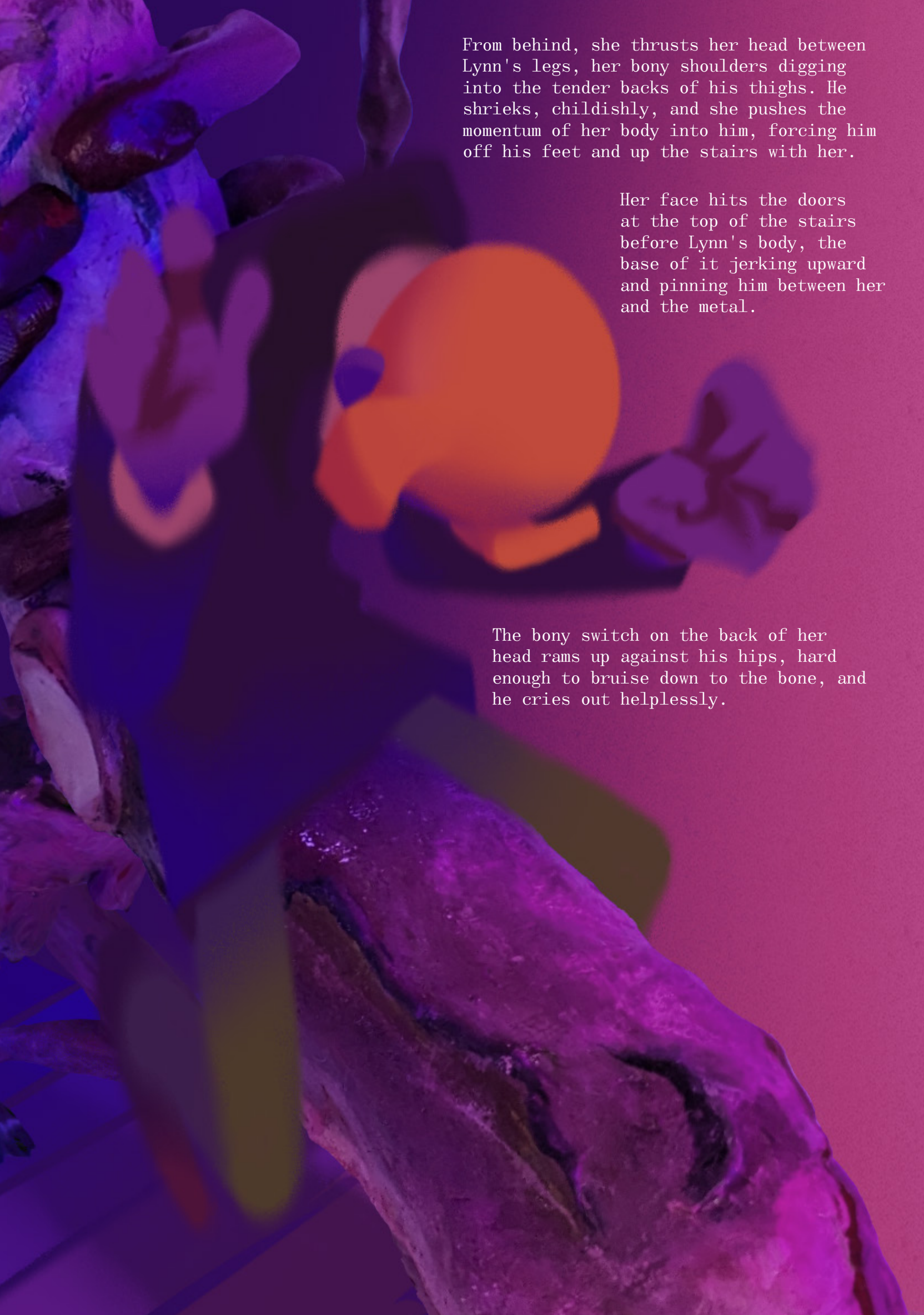


Dropping its head again to the ground, it breathes hard, pausing in its pursuit.

When he turns and runs he takes the steps two at a time, but she is held for only a moment by her exhaustion. She lunges at him up the stairs, and in a single trembling propulsion closes what little distance separates them.



From only a foot away, it exudes heat that Lynn can feel rolling off it in waves. Thick, oily sweat pools visibly in the crevices of its body.



From behind, she thrusts her head between Lynn's legs, her bony shoulders digging into the tender backs of his thighs. He shrieks, childishly, and she pushes the momentum of her body into him, forcing him off his feet and up the stairs with her.

Her face hits the doors at the top of the stairs before Lynn's body, the base of it jerking upward and pinning him between her and the metal.

The bony switch on the back of her head rams up against his hips, hard enough to bruise down to the bone, and he cries out helplessly.

He's scrambling before he's aware of it, nails clattering and palms banging against the smooth metal. There is no purchase to be found on the surface of it.

In the frenzied haze, his right arm drops to the side, and his fingertips sink into the plastic concave of a button.

Unable to sustain the weight, her neck gives out again, dropping her head to the ground and bringing Lynn with it. He barely catches himself, his knees wobbly and unprepared for the jolt.

The elongated snout of her face is still between his legs, radiating heat and thick sweat. Steam rises from her raw skin.

Lynn pulls away from her, unsticking his legs from her great jowls as he stands.

He looks down at her briefly and is so overcome by nausea that he jerks his head back up at once.



A plaque above the doors lights up, and they slide apart, vibrating along their tracks. Lynn pushes through them as soon as there's enough room for him to squeeze through, spinning to press the button to shut the doors.

The thing remains in front of the elevator, on its feet still but struggling again to lift its head.

It hisses, oozing spittle and blood from a mouth it cannot keep open, and Lynn watches with wide, wet eyes.

"I'm sorry," he says.

His voice is tremulous and high, breaking amid his whispers.

"I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm so sorry." His breath hitches in his throat as he hammers the button. The doors are beginning to close.

"I'm so sorry, please, please, please."

She's rising again now, her enormous head lifting from the concrete stairs, and his urgency redoubles in helplessness.

Halfway closed.

There is no space for her to fit by the time she lunges, but he flinches just the same.



He is aware of nothing but the figure rising in front of him, incognizant as he slides to his knees on the floor of the elevator, his arm still lifted to keep his finger on the button.

Her skull crunches against the doors hard enough to dent the metal of the outside. Lynn cowers now in earnest, scrambling backwards into a far corner.

When she strikes the doors again they're almost completely shut, and she's screaming again before she makes contact, impossibly loud.

The doors meet, and she's still thrashing and screaming behind them, beating herself against the metal.

Lynn can still hear her when the elevator starts rising, can hear her when she's far beneath him.

He has not yet come enough to his senses to wipe the mucus and drool from his face.



He doesn't move from his spot in the corner as she recedes.

Trembling on the floor, he digs his fingernails into his scalp and weeps as silently as he can.

He remains a sniveling pile on the floor, curling in on himself in preparation. His flinch is premature. When the elevator stops, it opens out into an empty hallway.

Nothing awaits him but outdated wallpaper.



He stares straight ahead out of the elevator, at the blank wall ahead of him, and after a hollowed out moment of deliberation, he rises.



The thin carpet quiets his footsteps, but he keeps looking over his shoulder.

There's an acute pressure in the atmosphere that is building, roiling up behind him, getting ready now to be too much soon.

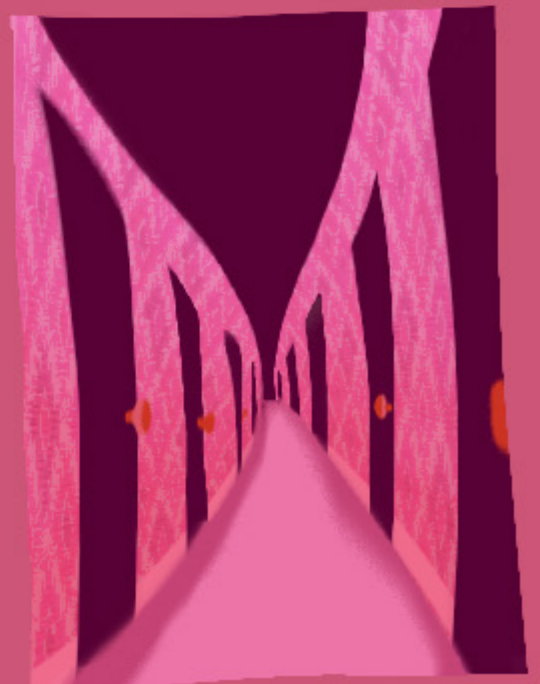
Nothing to see here.



Nothing to watch out for.

There's no sound or motion behind any of the doors he passes; they're not for him.

He knows which door he's headed to.



He's hardly conscious of how he's moving, breathing quietly through his mouth as he approaches and lays his hand on the door.

It takes more effort than it should to open it, as if there were something in the way on the other side.

The door's cheap latex paint feels sticky and strange, wet from the sweat of his palm.

He only opens it far enough to slip through, turning his shoulders and stepping in sideways.



The smell is vile at the doorway, new and harsh.

Right next to the kitchen is always where
it's the worst. It is rancid here, more
intimately so than Markus' house.

Rotten milk, mildew and cheap body spray. The floor is lined with
debris. Packaging from microwave meals and mail-in order products,
dirty laundry, and out of place decorations overwhelm the space;
a clump of colorful acrylic garments is huddled in front of the
door, partially jammed under it.



Lynn moves through the place with the accepting dread of one dreaming.



There's a window on the far end of the apartment that is definitely open, but the curtains are drawn. The sounds of the street outside leak in through the opening, but the room feels more claustrophobic for it.

A few stories down, the sound of swaths of air being whipped and displaced is punctuated by the ripping peel of car engines revving. It's warm inside already, and the air from the street is hot and heavy like foul breath, weighed down by smog.

The thought to look out the window crosses Lynn's mind, but it is followed by some ambiguous internal assurance that there is nothing outside he ought to see.



His fingers curl around the edge of the door delicately, and he's conscientious even of the sound of them brushing against the dry wood.



A living mass is at rest
atop the covers in the bedroom.

She groans his words back at him.

NEED

Her hopelessness is a thick syrup,
poured directly over his head.

NEED, WHAT DOESN'T SHE NEED, WHAT DOES HE THINK
SHE HAS NOW THAT WOULD KEEP HER FROM NEEDING
EVERYTHING SHE POSSIBLY COULD.
WHAT IN HER LIFE HAS SHE BEEN GIVEN
THAT HASN'T BEEN TAKEN FROM HER
WHAT DOES SHE HAVE NOW THAT
WON'T BE TAKEN
IMMINENTLY.
LIKELY BY HIM.

SHE NEEDS A NAP, BUT SHE CAN'T EVEN HAVE THAT WITH
HIM AROUND. COUSE HER TO ASK A QUESTION,
BRUSH HER OFF WHILE SHE'S ANSWERING YOU.
IT'S DIFFICULT TO FEEL SORRY FOR HIM, AFFICULT
FOR HIM TO FEEL SORRY FOR HIMSELF.
IT'S BEEN SO LONG SINCE HE'S BEEN INTO CHECK ON HER,
NO- HE'S NEVER CHECKED ON HER!



NEVER ONLY SINCE HE'S PUT HER HERE.
HOW WONDERFUL, WONDERFUL FOR HIM.

OH, SHE KNOWS, SHE WAS NEVER
ANY FUN TO BE AROUND. THERE IS A REASON
ALL HER FRIENDS ABANDONED HER.

IT MUST BE LIKE SHE NEVER EVEN EXISTED AFTER ALL, AND A REASON YOUR FATHER
AS LONG AS SHE NEVER LETS OUT, IT'S NO PROBLEM! DID THE SAME. IT MAKES SENSE THAT
SHE CAN ONLY IMAGINE HOW MUCH HE'S DREADING YOU THINK YOU HAVE BETTER THINGS TO DO. WHY
HER LAST DAY HERE. THINK OF THE WOMAN WHO MADE YOU,
WHO NURTURED YOU. WHAT PURPOSE

WHAT MUST HE HAVE BEEN DOING ALL THIS TIME? SOMETHING BETTER, SOMETHING
MORE PLEASANT & MORE FUN THAN TAKING ANY YOURSELF ANY FURTHER FOR HER?
RESPONSIBILITY FOR WHAT HE DID TO HER. WOULD IT SERVE TO DELAY
NO, SHE UNDERSTANDS.



The space in the doorway
Lynn currently occupies needs
him in it to hold the world
around it in place.

If he moves,
the whole building will collapse.

AND YOUR FATHER WAS THE SAME! CHECKED OUT, BITTER-QUIET & DRUNK OUT HIS SKULL EVERY NIGHT, SHE COULD HAVE HANDLED IT, COULD HAVE LEFT — IF IT HADN'T BEEN FOR YOU.

SHE STAYED FOR YOU.

SHE TOOK CARE OF YOU.

BUT NOW YOU JUST LIKE EVERYONE, JUST LIKE YOUR FATHER, HAVE ABANDONED HER.

GONE, SHE NEEDS YOU GONE, SO SHE CAN DIE HERE IN PEACE, ALONE.

LIKE YOU WANT HER TO, LIKE YOU'VE ALWAYS WANTED HER TO, LIKE EVERYONE'S BEEN WAITING ON HER TO,

IT HAD BEEN HELL, BEING YOUNG, JUST LIKE IT IS NOW.

She stirs in her pile of blankets, prostrated and gasping to keep up with the passion of her own speech.

YOU COME AROUND ONLY WHEN IT SUITS YOU, TOO LATE TO DO ANYTHING MEANINGFUL, TOO LATE TO HELP HER,

AND NOW YOU ASK IF SHE NEEDS ANYTHING?

AND WHAT DO YOU THINK OF THAT, LYNNIE? WHAT WILL YOU DO WHEN SHE'S GONE?

WILL YOU BE HAPPY? WILL YOU DANCE?

SHE USED TO DANCE, WHEN SHE WAS YOUR AGE.

"I WOULD MISS YOU."

"I WOULD MISS YOU. I'M SORRY, I WON'T GO AGAIN, I'M SO, I'M SO..."

His crying is muted, but his voice is swollen with his throat.
He won't get another word out of her now, not from where he stands in the doorway.

She can't dance anymore.

She wants him with her,
in the bed,
but she won't command
it of him aloud.



Why should she have to?
Of all people, he should
know where he ought to be.

He breathes through his mouth, lips twitching against his teeth in semblance of speech. There are no words for this feeling, and in the midst of it of his interior collapses, leaving him wordless and delayed.

It's hot, and he doesn't think to take off his coat. In the doorway he stays with eyes wide, dry and bulging in the dim light. He doesn't want to get in bed with her.

HE DOESN'T WANT TO! HOW INSULTING,
HE'S NOT INTERESTED! HOW SAD, HE CAN'T BRING HIMSELF EVEN
TO TOUCH HER, AFTER EVERYTHING.

She moves and sobs aloud;
he clutches himself like a child.



A stylized illustration featuring a woman with a very long, prominent nose, looking upwards. She has dark hair and is wearing a red top. The background is a light tan color. Large, three-dimensional, blocky Chinese characters in a vibrant blue color are scattered around her. One character, '美' (Mei), is at the top right. Another character, '年' (Nian), is on the left. A third character, '天' (Tian), is in the middle. The woman is positioned in the lower foreground, looking up towards the characters. The overall style is graphic and modern.

From an outsider's perspective, Lynn is perpetually in the early stages of learning that some things cannot be weathered by cowering. He appeals, constantly, to the better nature of his opposition, and resolutely learns nothing on being denied.

It's hard to contend the reality of Lynn with the memory of him, but the reality is that he has always been slow. He'd been assigned aids until his second year of high school, and he'd taken classes over the summer every year.

He still graduated a year late.

Knowing this, it's possible that he really is trying. It's possible that he's been trying, all the time.

Either is as frustrating as the other.

ARE YOU STILL STANDING OUT THERE?

She has surpassed wretchedness, and he feels it with her but cannot bring himself to speak.
So you, too, have betrayed her.

LEAVE, THEN, LEAVE HER,
GET AS FAR AWAY
AS YOU CAN
FROM HER, IF
THAT'S REALLY WHAT
YOU WANT.



PUT YOURSELF
AWAY FOR A WHILE
AND SEE HOW YOU
LIKE IT.

THERE YOU ARE, NOW YOU'VE GOT YOUR VOICE. NOW YOU'VE GOT SOMETHING TO SAY.
TOO LATE! SHE DOESN'T WANT TO HEAR IT, SHE KNOWS HOW YOU REALLY FEEL.

YOU COULDN'T
HIDE HOW
MUCH YOU HATE
HER ENOUGH
TO COMFORT HER
FOR A SINGLE MOMENT.



SHE CAN HARDLY STAND
TO LOOK AT YOU.
GO! GO AWAY,
GO PUT YOURSELF
AWAY. GO PUT
YOURSELF AWAY, AND
DON'T COME BACK UNTIL
SHE COMES TO GET YOU.



He steps backwards, slowly. The sound of his motion feels like its own offense, but he can't bring himself to turn around or even look back at where he's stepping. Unsteady on the refuse of the floor, he trembles on his way back across the room, flinching every time his dress shoe collides with anything solid.

The ground in front of the closet door is clear.

He can hear the door to the bedroom opening as he shuts himself in.



Silently, he continues weeping. He doesn't so much as reach up to wipe his nose; the snot that pools on his upper lip continues to drip without slowing.

He can hear her moving around outside. It is as it always was.

Inside, the stillness of the closet is oppressive. Enough of the clothes in it are dirty to make the whole small room smell profoundly worn by her. The space where her jaw meets her neck is here, with the insides of her upper thighs and her underarms.



It has been worse, before, but
it's difficult to recall when.

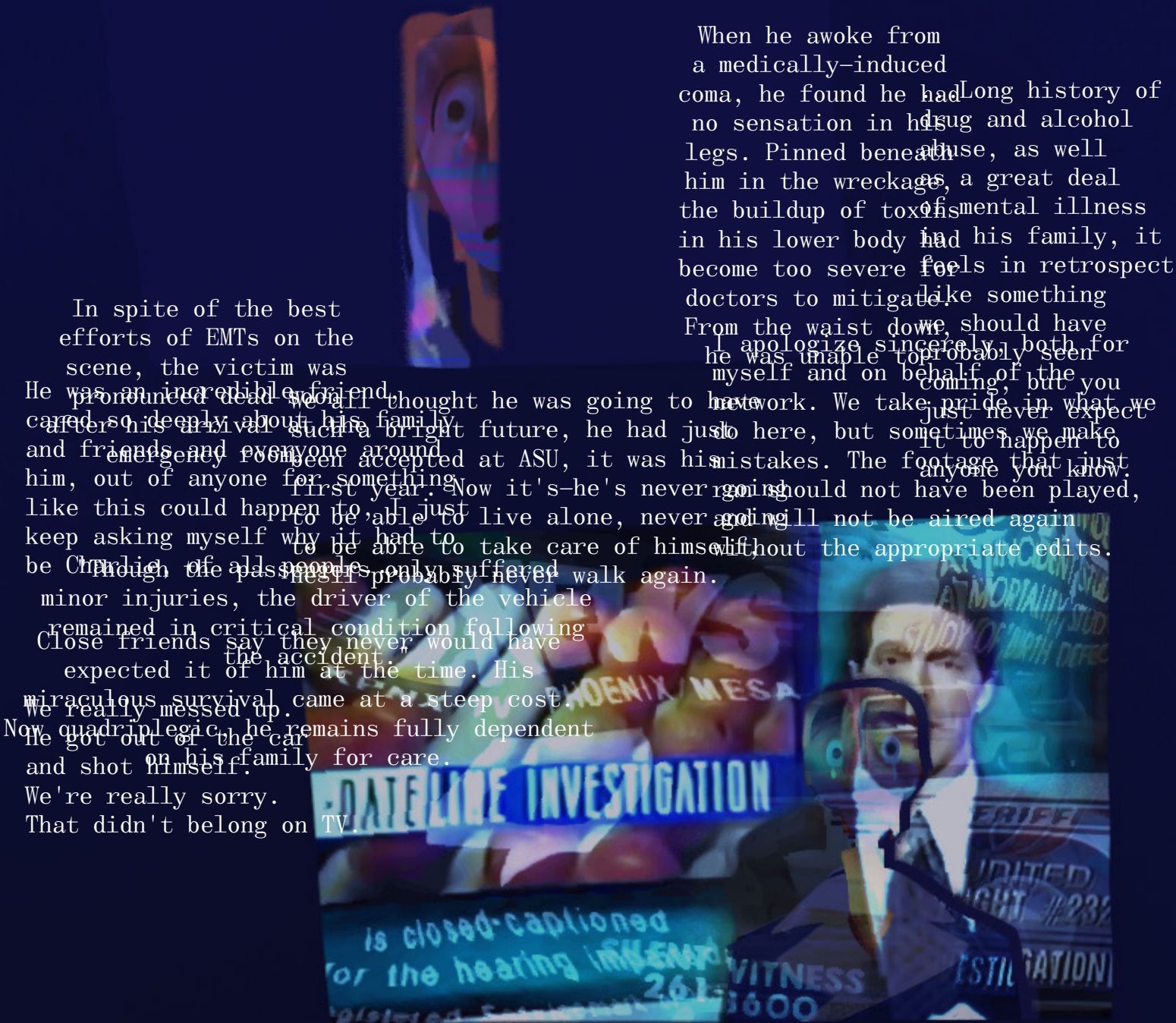
Lynn raises his hands to the sides of his head, kneading his fingers into the hair hanging against the sides of his face. He winds strands of it like thread around his knuckles and pulls down hard enough to hurt his temples.

In the living room, he can hear her settling down on the couch. He makes the conscious decision to hold his breath until the TV set clunks on. Impossibly loud through the door of the closet and sharper, clearer than any broadcast from his childhood, the sound is immediately suffocating.

"Found in the basement of the suburban home, the victim was severely malnourished and had lacerations on his chest and face. He was taken to a hospital, where he remains in critical condition."

Another recording cuts in, seamlessly, as if the channel has been changed. The announcer is the same. His voice is familiar.

Lynn presses his legs together so hard it hurts, one hand squeezed between them. Muscles clench under the soft skin of his thighs, and the sound of the television in the other room is a magnet that attracts all of him at once.



When he awoke from a medically-induced coma, he found he had no sensation in his legs. Pinned beneath him in the wreckage of the buildup of toxins in his lower body had become too severe for doctors to mitigate. From the waist down, he was unable to move. I apologize sincerely, both for myself and on behalf of the coming, but you have to work. We take pride in what we just never expect it to happen to anyone you know. The footage that just should not have been played, going will not be aired again without the appropriate edits.

In spite of the best efforts of EMTs on the scene, the victim was pronounced dead. He was an incredible friend, cared so deeply about his family and friends and everyone around him, out of anyone for something like this could happen to, I just keep asking myself why it had to be. Through the passage of time, only suffered minor injuries, the driver of the vehicle remained in critical condition following the accident. Close friends say they never would have expected it of him at the time. His miraculous survival came at a steep cost. We really messed up. Now quadriplegic, he remains fully dependent on his family for care. We're really sorry. That didn't belong on TV.

It is something above empathy that overcomes him in grief. A hole is opened up in him, into which it all sinks; the jarring, sudden pain and the mildewy bereavement that follows. He can think of nothing else.



Already hot with tears, Lynn's face is contorted and dark, lips pulled back over his teeth in a silent grimace. His broad shoulders shake with the rest of him in jerky arrhythmia.

This is a natural state. The prospect of leaving of his own volition has never occurred to him.

Something on the floor wraps a hand around Lynn's ankle passively, a touch denoting a desire for attention more than anything else.

Lynn stares straight ahead without moving as it collects itself, rising waist-high. It seems like it must be shifting, swaying in place, but it's difficult to tell; Lynn can't bring himself to turn his face directly towards it. In this way, it remains cataclysmically vague.

It sways more deeply into him, and Lynn leans back, raising his hands and managing a quiet vocalization of resistance through tears.

Shaking his head reflexively, meaninglessly, he compresses himself into the dirty mound of fabric. It feels like someone is tightening his belt.

Only a little light is sneaking in under the door, but his teary eyes are adjusting to the dark.

Aghast in the certainty of sensation, Lynn casts his eyes down to avoid looking at the mass directly as it folds itself around him.

However long Cam has been watching, it seems that he's only now realizing what he's looking at. He grins up at him, widely and without shame.

Horrified, Lynn doubles over, bending at the waist furtively and covering himself.



A scream bubbles in his throat but does not pop.

A hand rises to his face, touching its forefinger to his mouth firmly enough to compress lips into exposed, crooked teeth.

The little thing holding itself to Lynn's side tightens its grip.



In a sequence of thoughts too rapid to remember once they've passed, Lynn recalls that Cam's baby teeth had been crooked, too. Some of them had been missing. "I think someone must have kicked them out," Lori had whispered the day she brought him home.

Lynn remembers how desperate she had been to get Cam to stop sucking his thumb when his adult teeth had started growing in.



The door of the closet swings open, and Lynn catches a glimpse of what appears to be a wall of pure flesh where the living room once was.

He falls back against the wall, covering his face, and feels the binding weight fall away from him.

Something across from him strains audibly, slamming into the walls, reeking of yellow chemical sweat.

The pile of clothes Cam had been beneath has been dispersed,
and the closet door swings limply.

In the living room, already halfway out the door,
the way Markus' fingers are knotted in Cam's hair
makes Lynn's stomach drop.



There's blood in his scalp; the hand that pulls him along is
big enough to wrap around his head, as if he were a toy.

He jerks and stumbles after Markus, his head forced too low to the ground to stay on his feet.

He doesn't resist, doesn't protest. When they round the corner to leave the apartment, Lynn only sees a flash of his face as he twists himself half upright again.



There's no way to make out his expression, but Lynn is struck by how small Cam seems, more petite than usual stooped next to the hulking frame dragging him along.

He can make himself seem so thoroughly developed at times; his youth is accentuated now by his slack-jawed absorption of the violence he is presented with.

Lynn remains in the living room,
alone in the doorway of the closet.

Everything feels sticky.

There has been no shift in the contents
of the room, but it feels abruptly
empty all the same.

He peers around, sniffing,
rubbing his eyes dry, struck
by the sense that there's
nothing left to be done here.



It's not unlike the feeling of moving, mess and all.

Briefly he recalls the piles of garbage
and newly-unwanted possessions he and
his mother had left behind every time
they'd left one sweltering one-bedroom
apartment for another.

There is nothing left to do here,
no one left to talk to.





Lynn walks out, shutting the door as he goes.

A stylized illustration of a hallway. A large, light-colored rug is pushed aside, revealing a dark floor. A dark door is partially open, with a small orange circle on it. The walls are covered in a pattern of small, light-colored squares. The overall style is abstract and modern.

The rug down the hallway
has been knocked askew.

Inconsequential collateral of Cam's
halfhearted fight to stay on his feet.

The worst of it is in front of the metal door to the
stairwell. The rug has been almost overturned, and
one of Cam's shoes is lodged in the doorway.

It's so flimsy that the door has
shut completely in spite of it.

Holes are worn through the sole, and the fabric is coming away from the rim in multiple places. The laces are outstandingly filthy, caked in mud.

Cam had resented being taught to tie his shoes as a child, and persistently refused the practice for years after he'd learned.

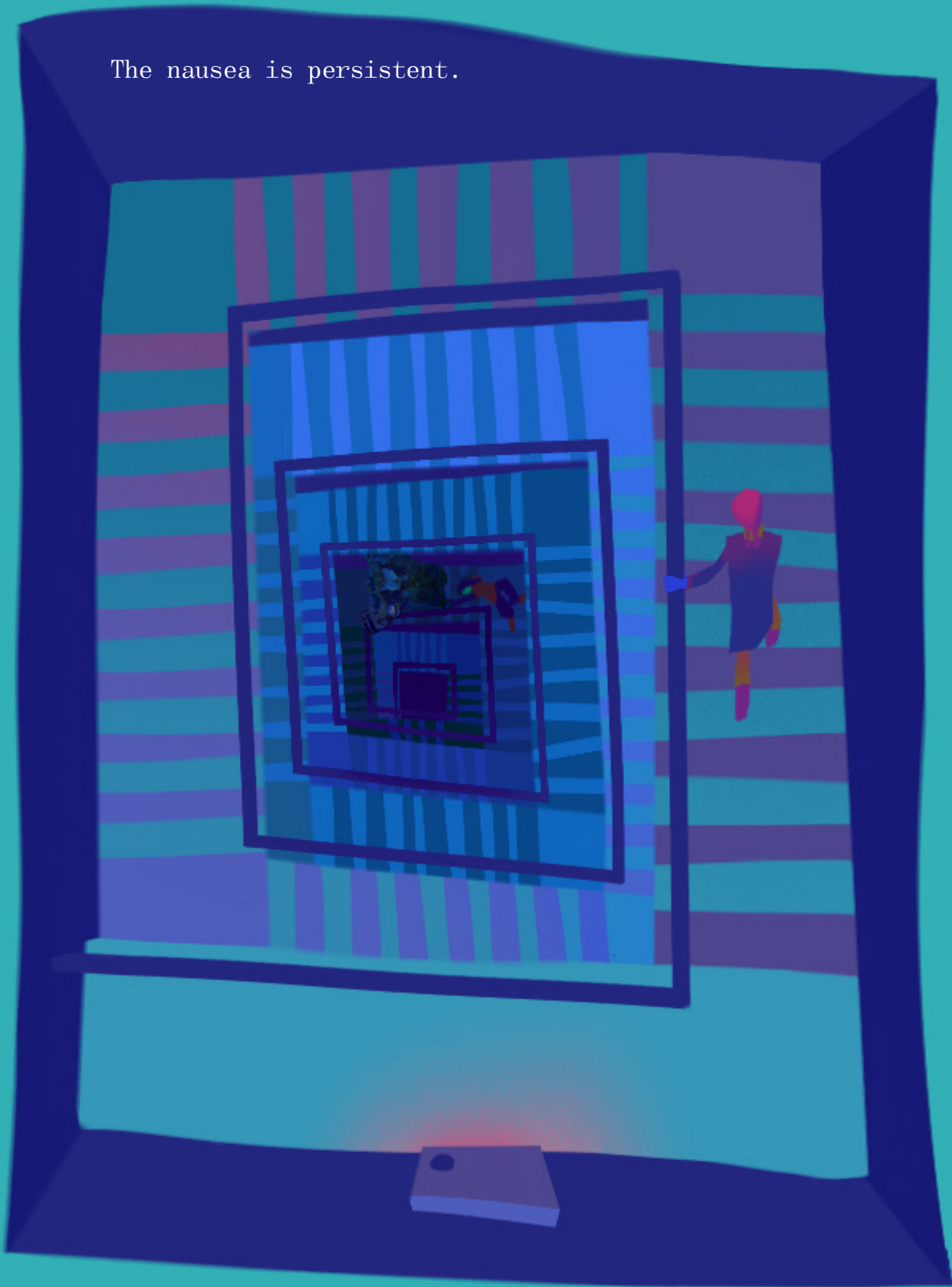
Opening the door takes a little more force than usual with the shoe lodged in the gap. It drops to the ground, and Lynn stoops in the doorway to pick it up in spite of the muck on it.



There's a hole in the canvas on the inner side of the shoe. On thoughtless impulse, he sticks his finger through it. The fabric gives and tears a little wider around his finger, and he is abruptly nauseated.

He slips through the door, bracing himself against it to muffle its closing clunk. The sound of his dress shoes, light on concrete steps, is muffled by audible struggling a few staircases down.

Heavy breathing and shoving, descending. Lynn's motions are thoughtless and puppetlike as he follows.



All the way down, Markus has dragged him already. The stairs are steep enough that there's no way Cam could have been standing, not the way he'd been held. Each step is lined with a strip of metal on the edge.

He waits for the sounds to quiet before he descends further, but it isn't long.

A few steps down at a time, and then stillness at the command of his own churning. Another few steps. When he has sunk by half a staircase in this way the stinging has risen above his collarbone, and he bends at the waist, turning to lurch noisily against the railing.

The bile is thick on his tongue as he swallows it, less distance than he had expected from his throat to the twisting bodies on the ground floor.

"I'm-!"

His apology comes out in a halfhearted gurgle.

The smaller of the two figures ceases struggling for a moment, gasping and twisting up at the space above.

Lynn clasps his hands first over his mouth, then his face, before whipping back over the stair railing.

Acidic humiliation drives him down the stairs with ridiculous urgency. He's not sure what he means to do when he gets there.

He doesn't have to be.

He is close enough that he might hear the air leave Cam's lungs as he's torn from where he kneels by the hair.

Ragdolling,
there is no resistance.





Through the doorway and back into the hall, his head makes contact with the wall opposite him before he collapses.

He does not stir.

The yawning behemoth steps over him, back down into the hallway, and turns fluidly, spinning on one heel to drive the other foot into his ribs. The sound he makes is instrumental, too high to be guttural. Pure air against tissue; woodwind.

From the doorway, it is like nothing Lynn has experienced in his life. He stands bent at the waist, diminishing himself openly.

Cam's head is at an odd angle, facing away from Lynn down the hall. He does not lift it, but Lynn can see his pupils shifting, back and forth. To Lynn, to the end of the hall, and back. It could mean anything.



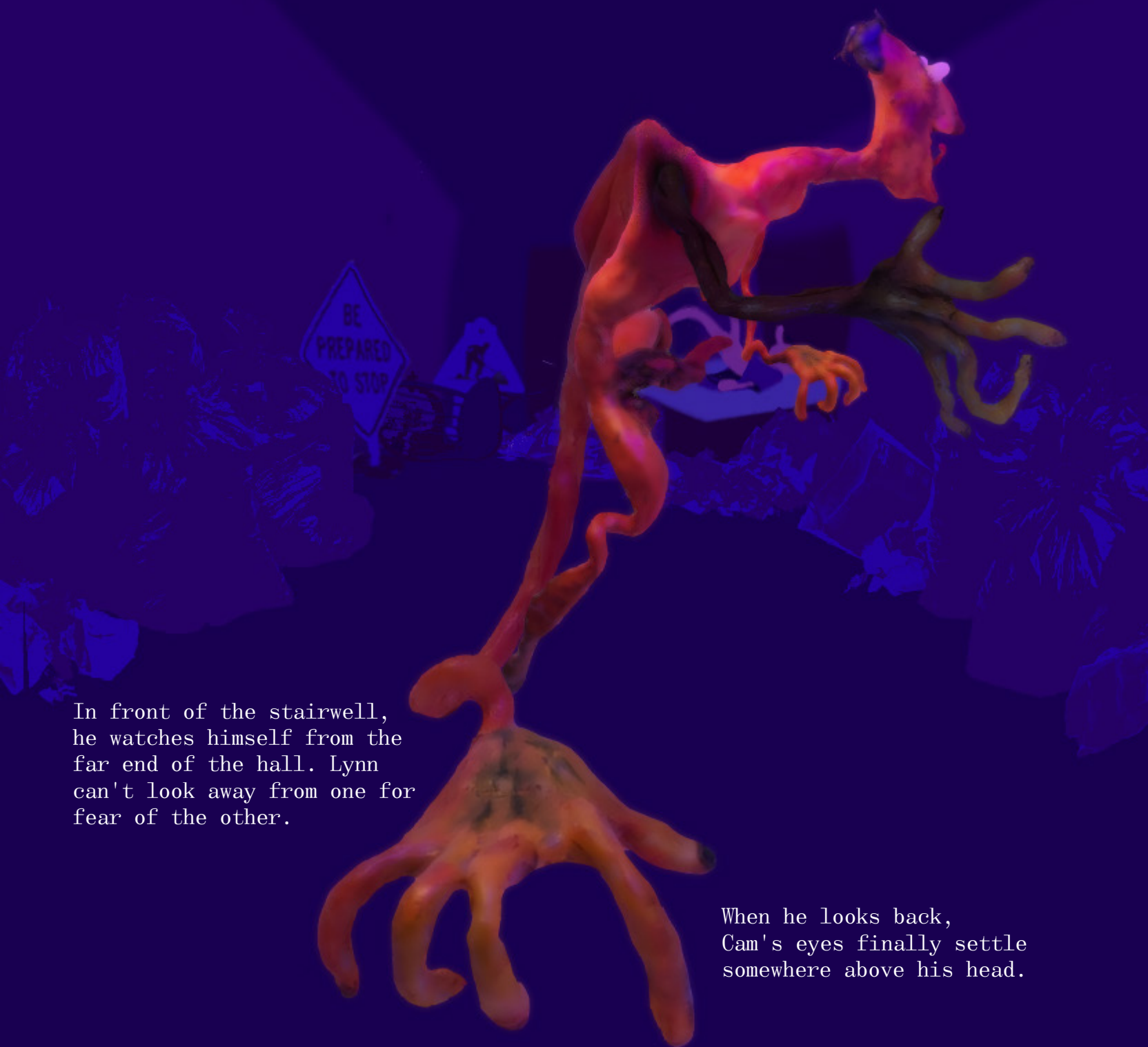
The thing at the end of the hallway churns and twitches of something like its own volition, grinding hips, grinding teeth, knuckles tight against themselves on the headboard.

Cam is here, too, at the end of the hallway, smaller with space and proximity to the bizarre thing convulsing above him.

His limbs are splayed; his whole body looks stretched out like candy, like a rubber toy.

In front of the stairwell, he watches himself from the far end of the hall. Lynn can't look away from one for fear of the other.

When he looks back, Cam's eyes finally settle somewhere above his head.



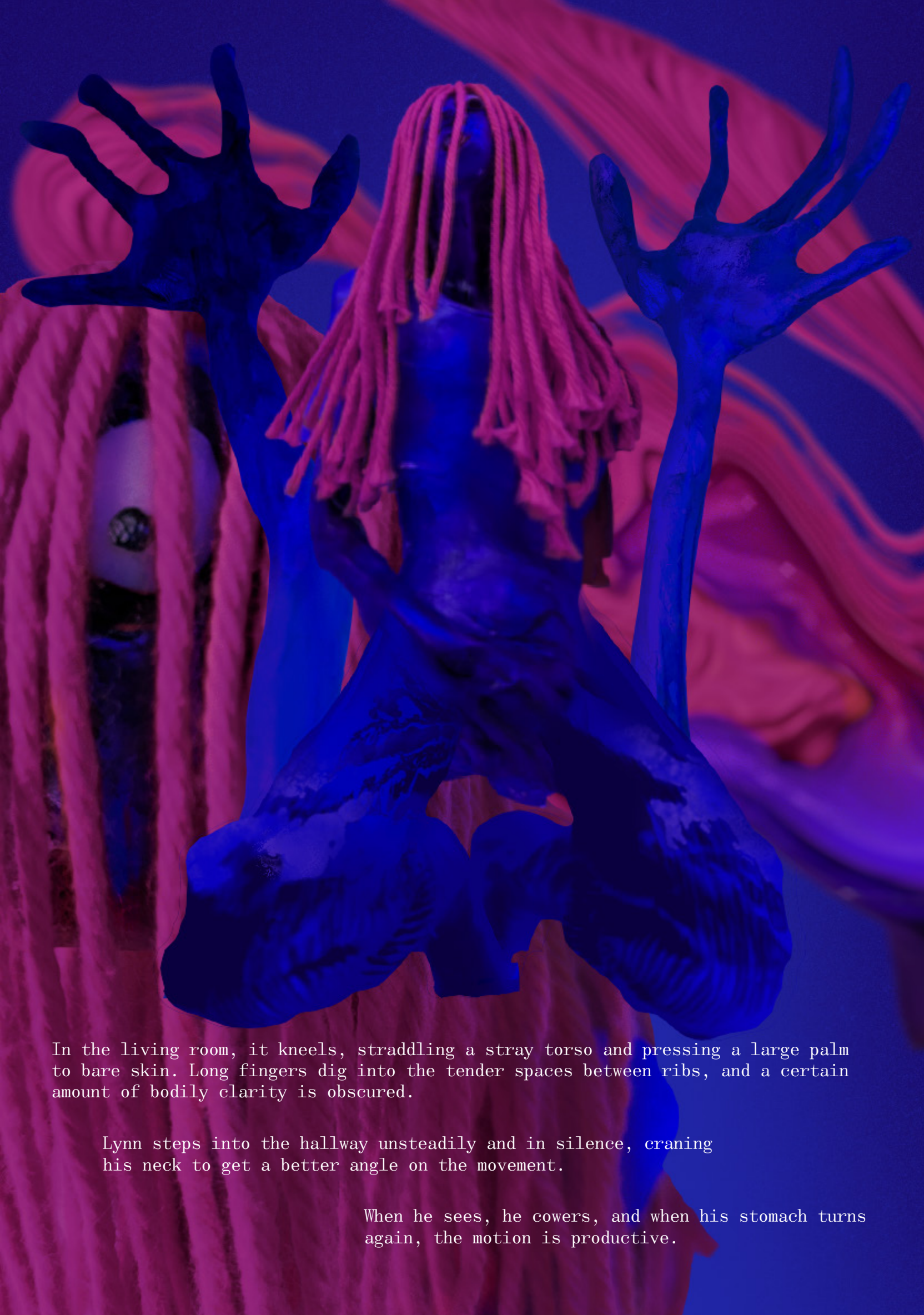
It's almost relieving.



The presence that drifts
out around him is not
quite insubstantial.



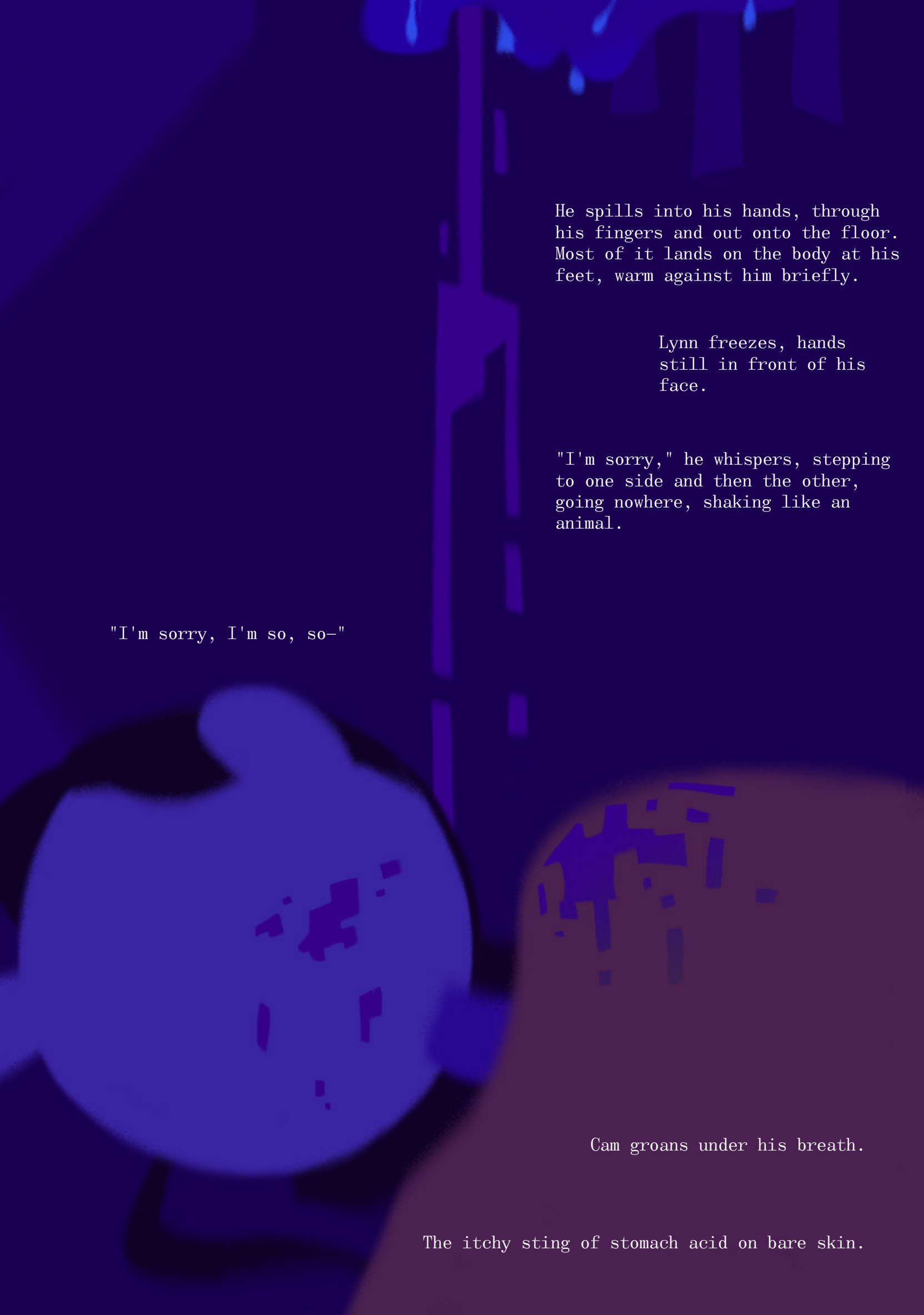
Lynn feels its
upper arm against
him as it passes
by, but finds
himself unable to
adequately cower.
He watches it move,
wraithlike, across the
hallway.



In the living room, it kneels, straddling a stray torso and pressing a large palm to bare skin. Long fingers dig into the tender spaces between ribs, and a certain amount of bodily clarity is obscured.

Lynn steps into the hallway unsteadily and in silence, craning his neck to get a better angle on the movement.

When he sees, he cowers, and when his stomach turns again, the motion is productive.



He spills into his hands, through his fingers and out onto the floor. Most of it lands on the body at his feet, warm against him briefly.

Lynn freezes, hands still in front of his face.

"I'm sorry," he whispers, stepping to one side and then the other, going nowhere, shaking like an animal.

"I'm sorry, I'm so, so—"

Cam groans under his breath.

The itchy sting of stomach acid on bare skin.



Lynn drops to one knee, hunched over him. He takes fistfuls of the body's shirt, wiping it with his hands to little affect.

"I'm so sorry, Cam, I'm so sorry," he's still gasping, panting between words to keep up with himself.

"I'm so, so, sorry."

His words seem insincere in light of his posture, still crouched over Cam as if awaiting a signal to flee.

The front door looks terribly appealing now, but there's so much to get past, so many things that could catch him if he runs.

He'll only get stuck.

He is suddenly aware that he can still hear the pained rutting of the thing into Cam down the hall.



Nothing intercepts the
rhythmlessness of its drumming.

There is the tremendous
and hideous feeling that he
is involved, that he has in
this house been made part of
an unsolvable equation.

His guilt, previously secluded, is now
compounded in connection to a schema
of unfamiliar cruelty.

It is natural suction, tidal, coming in
waves. He has just learned that his house
burnt down, he has just learned that
someone died.

His mouth is open and he makes a dry,
unconscious sound. Maybe the teenage frame at
his feet can hear him over the distant grunting.

The world has become incredibly small.

He's still holding onto the shirt, gripping
it so hard his hands shake.

Faintly, a dismal little sigh from the living room. Lynn doubles over
and heaves as the front door swings open.

Being shoved with enough force to knock it all the way back against its hinges, it could have slammed against the wall hard enough to shake the house.

Two burst bags of garbage swimming in their own contents compress against the wall and the weight of the door.

The room is decompressed in an instant, flooded in the cold light of the real.

Cam is too far away for Lynn to tell what he's looking at.

Lynn can't think of what to say.

Cam strides across the living room stonefaced, passing the huffing tangle on the floor without a glance.

Long steps to the dresser by the TV, deft shuffling through the top drawer.

The electric fear of humiliation bites down Lynn's back again.

Cam shuts the dresser drawer loudly, gives the gun a once over but does not rack it.

It doesn't matter.

He locks eyes with Lynn on his way into the kitchen, raises both hands and waves them sarcastically.

The gun in one, his inhaler in the other.

Disconcerted into stillness, Lynn can hear the TV behind all the writhing.

Has it been on the whole time?

"I'm sorry," he whimpers again.

He hardly has to think to say it at all. "I'm sorry, I didn't - you, you were here and..."

It doesn't even sound like anything more than muscle memory.

Cam pauses on his way out and shows his front teeth crookedly.

"Don't have to apologize to me," he says.

"I feel worse for the other guy."



Lynn presses his lips together and swallows his words.
His mouth is so dry it hurts.

Kneeling in place, he turns his head to watch Cam nudge
open the door to the garage and lumber through.

Abruptly, he realizes that he is being left alone in
the house again. Only this compels him to let go of
Cam's shirt and scramble after his stepbrother.



The garage does not smell nearly as foul as the kitchen. Lynn hadn't been in a state to notice before. Cam dawdles by the reloading table, leaning over it like he's looking for something.

Apparently dissatisfied, he clucks his tongue and steps back.

"Place is such a mess. Could you imagine living somewhere like this?"

Lynn isn't sure if it's time to talk yet. He presses his lips together and shakes his head quickly, like a child. Cam stands on his toes to pull the manual release cord to the door, not facing him.

"As an adult, I mean. Living here. This is your life. You think you'd like that?"

He looks back over his shoulder at Lynn, awaiting response.

In the absence of one, he drones on.

"You'd like it fine, I bet. You'd get adjusted to it. Could probably get adjusted to anything."

Grasping the handle, he pulls the door up and open.

Neither of them knows what to do with the quiet. It feels awkward, unplanned for, like he'd had to stop and take a breath when he shouldn't have.

The outside air is an overwhelming relief to Lynn. A few steps outside the garage with Cam, he can take in nothing else.

Cam is borderline statuesque but for the rubbing of his index finger against the textured grip of the gun.

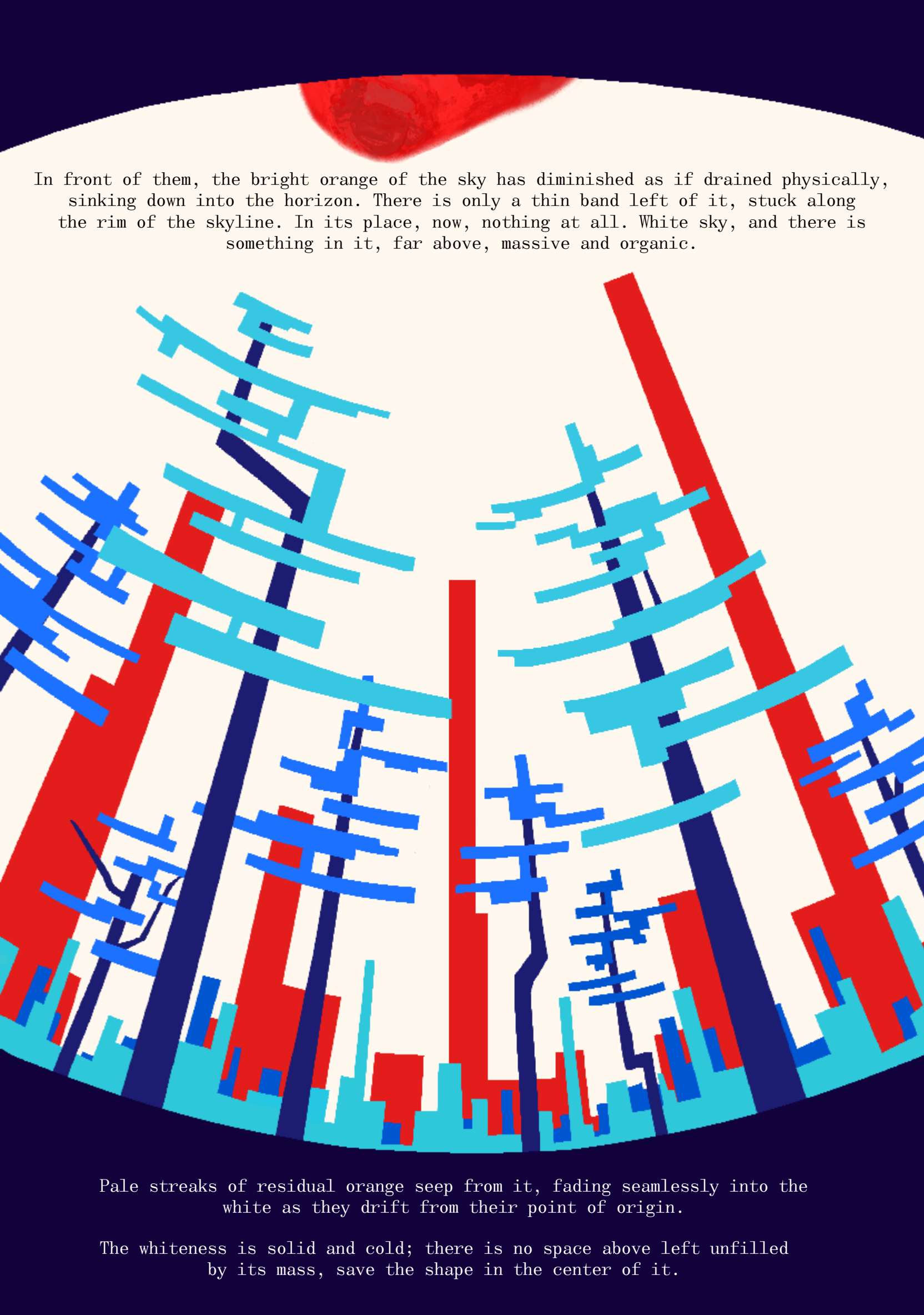


The tears and mucus that have just begun to dry form a briny crust on Lynn's face, and he feels it crack against his cheeks as he catches his breath.

He can feel Cam staring up at him, measured and blank.

He does not look back.





In front of them, the bright orange of the sky has diminished as if drained physically, sinking down into the horizon. There is only a thin band left of it, stuck along the rim of the skyline. In its place, now, nothing at all. White sky, and there is something in it, far above, massive and organic.

Pale streaks of residual orange seep from it, fading seamlessly into the white as they drift from their point of origin.

The whiteness is solid and cold; there is no space above left unfilled by its mass, save the shape in the center of it.

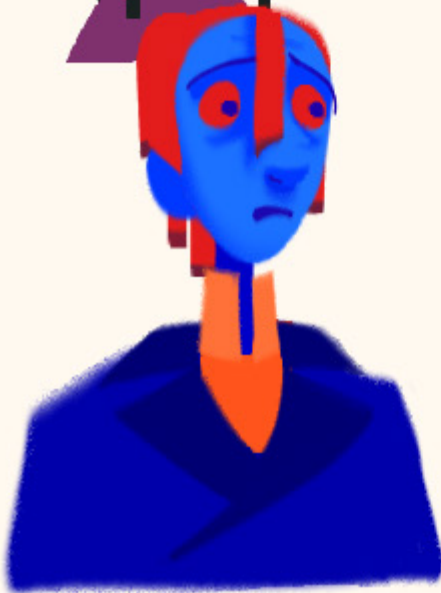
When Lynn pulls himself from the horizon line to look down at Cam, it is apparent that Cam has not been looking up at him. Only a fraction of the form above is visible over the roof of the garage, but it is unmistakably this that he is fixated on.

A muscle in his cheek twitches uncharacteristically, and for a second in the frigid light he makes a strange face that means nothing at all.

His eyes slide over Lynn without focus.

"Get the door for me.
You can wait in the car if you want."

Lynn watches as he goes, motionless for a few seconds before he fully processes what was said to him. By the time he has the garage door closed, Cam is already several feet away from the car, stalking off with the rope that had been sitting on the hood.





This route through
the forest may well
be a completely
different one
from the one they
took earlier this
afternoon.

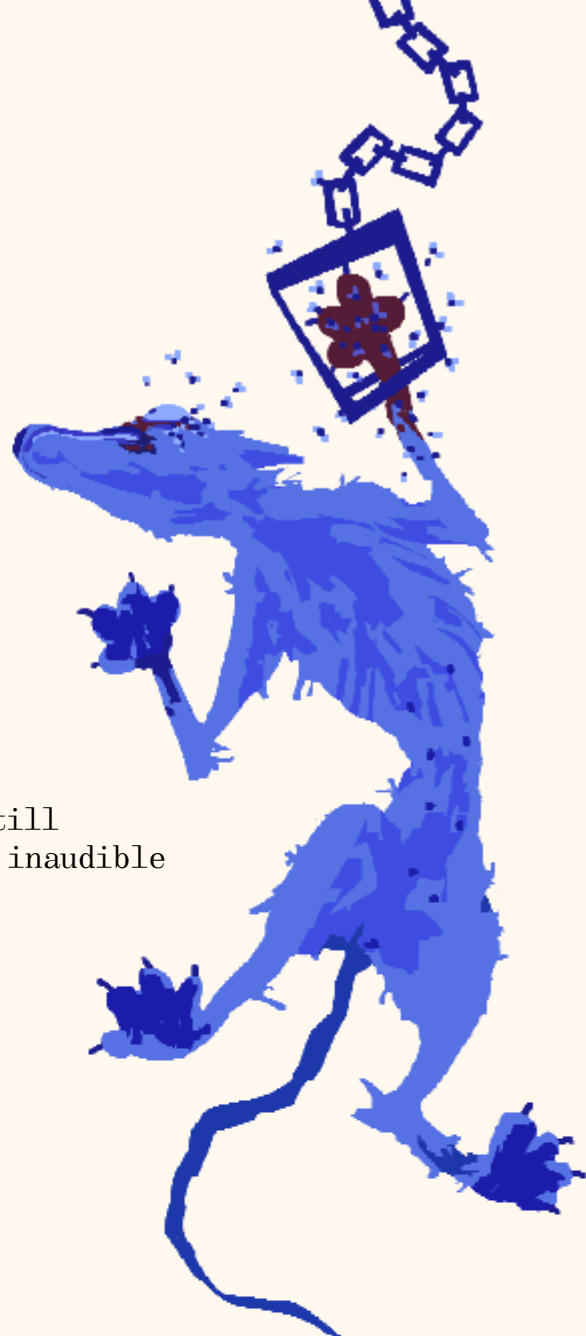
The lighting pounding through the trees is so
hard and pale that it obscures distance.

Sharp-lit needles comprise the entire world
above eye level, and Lynn walks unsteadily
with his hands in front of him to keep from
colliding with tree trunks that only look to
be several feet away from him.

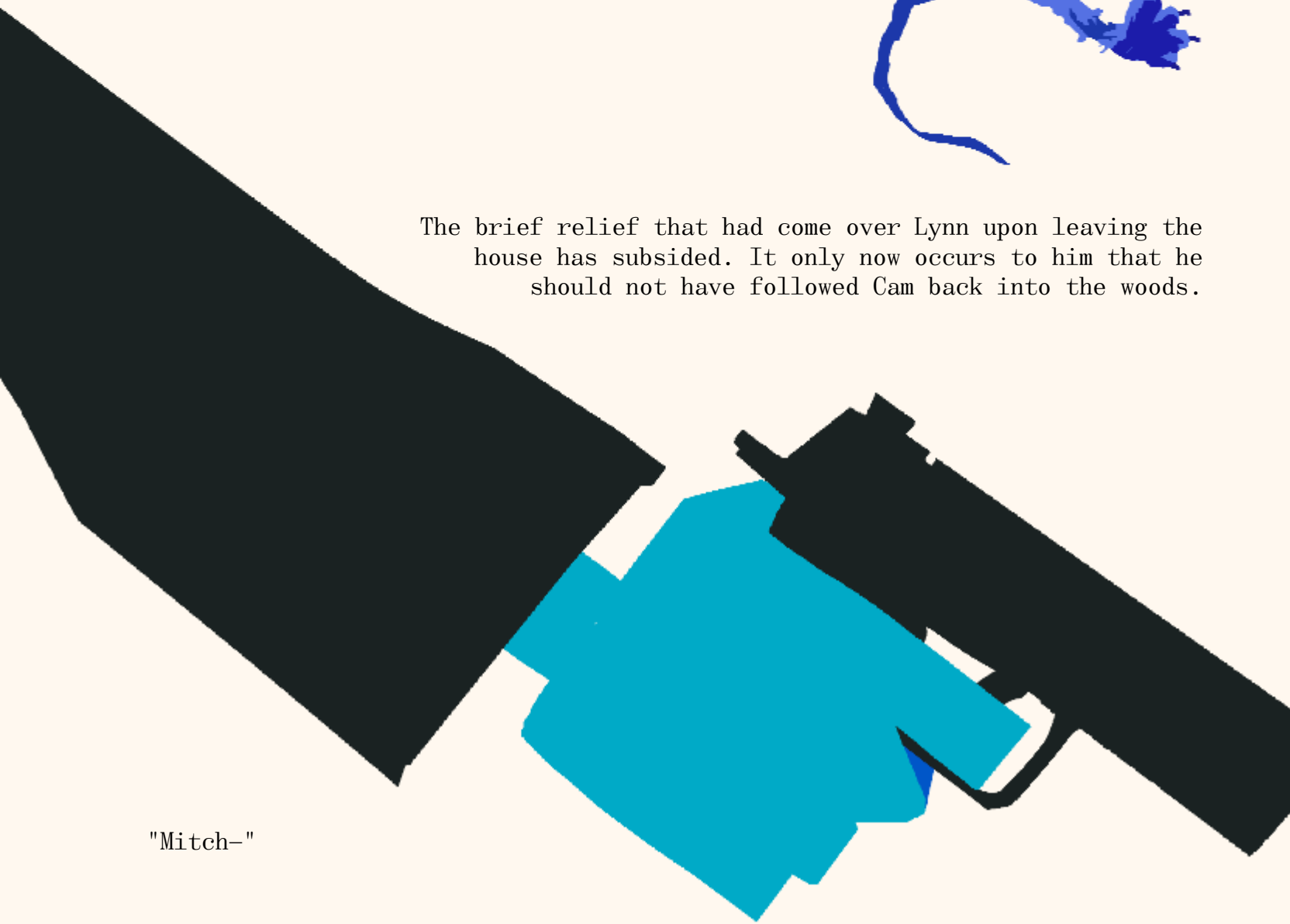
When they come upon the trap again,
the coyote is already cowering.



It's markedly more lethargic than before, still
and staring up at them. Its growl is almost inaudible
under the sound of their halted shuffling.



The brief relief that had come over Lynn upon leaving the
house has subsided. It only now occurs to him that he
should not have followed Cam back into the woods.



"Mitch-"

The name becomes a grimace in his mouth,
swallowed in the sound of the shot.

Lynn flinches so hard he
almost loses his footing.





He can't tell if Cam
hit his mark or not,
and he doesn't look up
to find out, covering
his face and crouching
low to the ground.

He is nearing a limit.

Cam stalks only a few steps off before realizing that Lynn is not following him. He
seizes him by the upper arm and pulls him to his feet as best he can. His enthusiasm
and Lynn's bedrattlement together make up for the difference in their size.

"Come on," he says, already urging Lynn forward, pulling him along now by the wrist.

"Come on, there's more."



"More," Lynn gasps faintly without understanding anything more than the force that drags him forward.

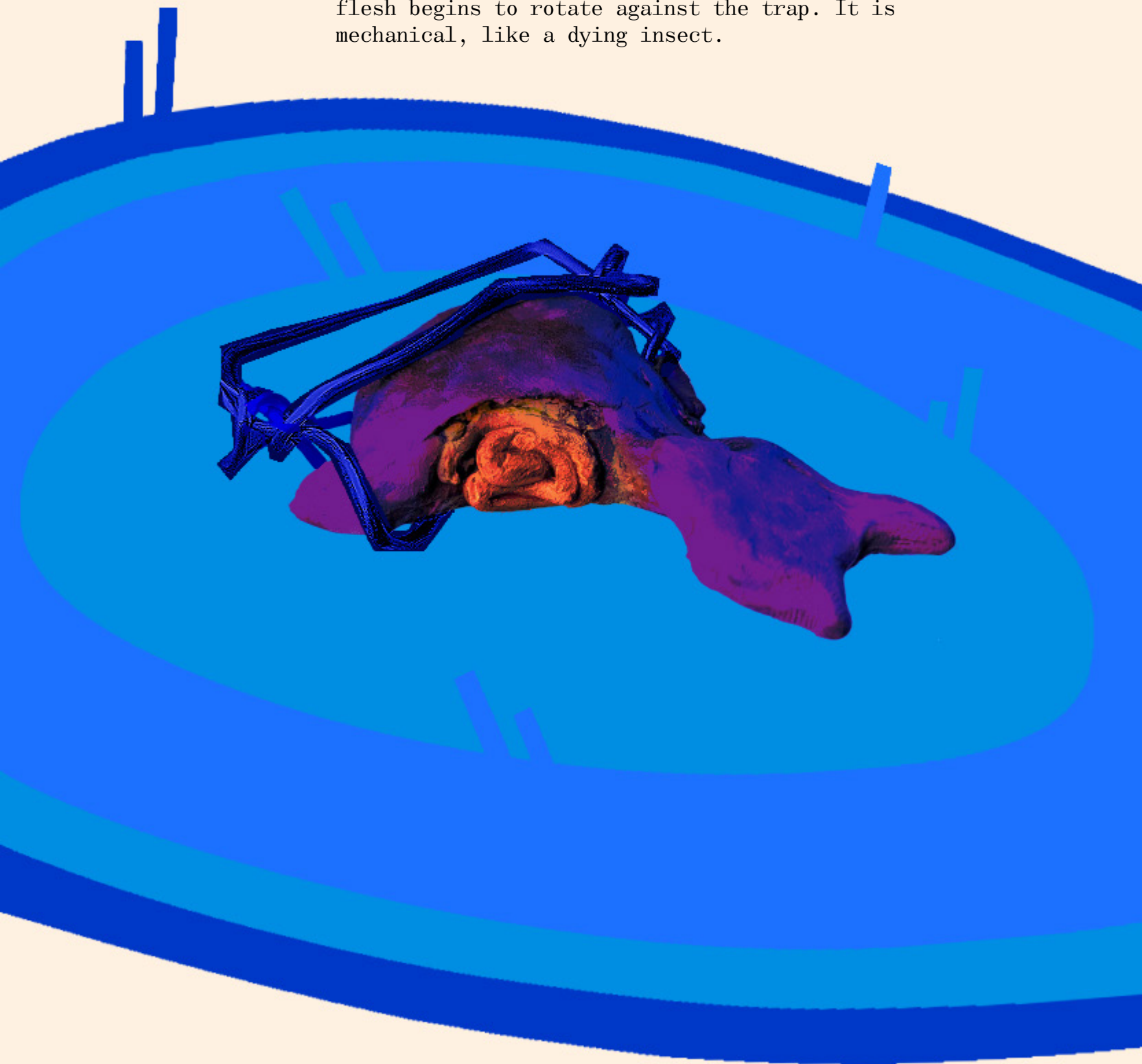
Cam doesn't hear him over the sound of their combined stumbling in the brush.

His grip on Lynn's forearm could be mechanical, were it not warm and slick with sweat.



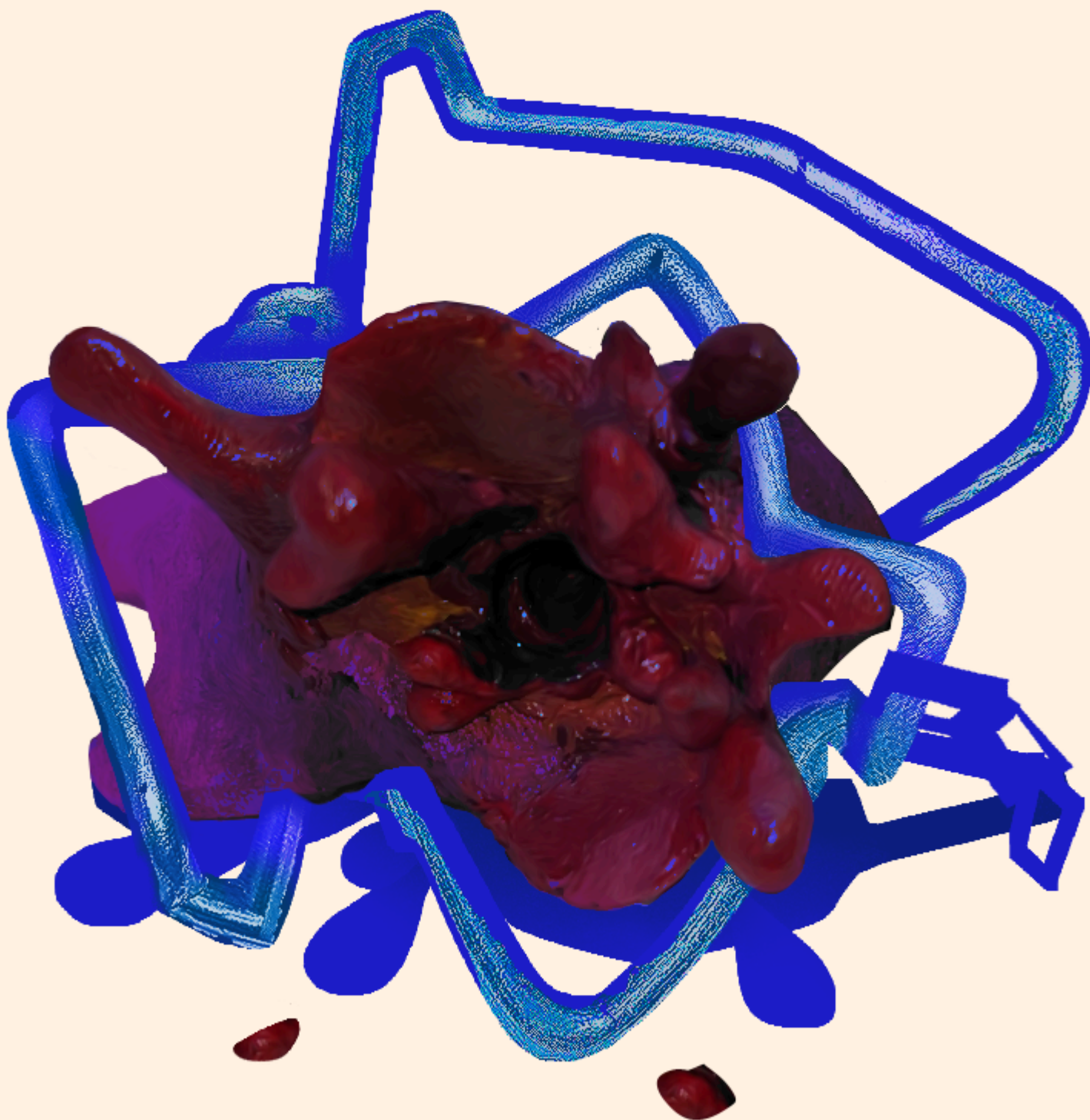
It isn't a long ways to the other trap. This one is amid a thick section of brush, with no clearing or semblance of a path leading to it. The body in it, too, is far more ambiguous. It is hardly animate. One of the little lumps, alone, squashed against metal.

This one is vague like the others are, more so, even, in this condition. A throaty wheeze rises in pitch as they approach, a raw nub of flesh begins to rotate against the trap. It is mechanical, like a dying insect.



Lynn is almost expecting it this time when Cam raises the gun, but not enough to look away.

There is something deeply piteous to him in the way the thing stops struggling after the hole is blown through it.



He yelps, and when he starts crying again it hurts, like all the water in him has previously been expelled and there is none left.

Cam can only ever remember Lynn crying quietly, but the choked sobbing next to him feels louder than it has a right to be. He whirls around, spitting and breathless with something like laughter.



"What? What are you crying about, what did you think was going to happen? No one's coming to help."

It is a miracle Lynn is able to collect himself enough for a reply, and another miracle still that Cam understands him through his animate weeping.

"You didn't have to kill it," he sobs.

"You didn't have to kill it!"

"Are you kidding?" Incredulous to the point of being hysterical, Cam is suddenly in Lynn's face with his voice raised. "Are you stupid?"

It's a genuine question. He leans in with his head tilted up and Lynn pulls back in equal measure, unsteadily, still weeping.

"You don't even know what it is."

There is finality in the statement.

Cam steps away with disgust plain on his face, and Lynn realizes as the pressure lifts from his foot that Cam had been standing on his toes.

When he lifts his eyes, Cam is over by the trap again. The little body is in pieces and Lynn looks away, gripped suddenly by the conviction that he does not have the right to look. Cam has no such scruples.

"You got one too, anyway," he says, without looking up. "In the house. You got a big one."

Lynn stares at him, blurry through residual tears.

"I didn't mean to," he whispers. "I didn't see it, didn't – I, didn't know –" Ungainly, he stammers into another wave of sobs, no shallower than before.

Cam is wrapping the rope around one end of the trap, clumsily, still holding the gun. "Didn't see it," he repeats, snorting. "Oh, you didn't see it. It was right in front of you, you had your hands out, you were all over it."

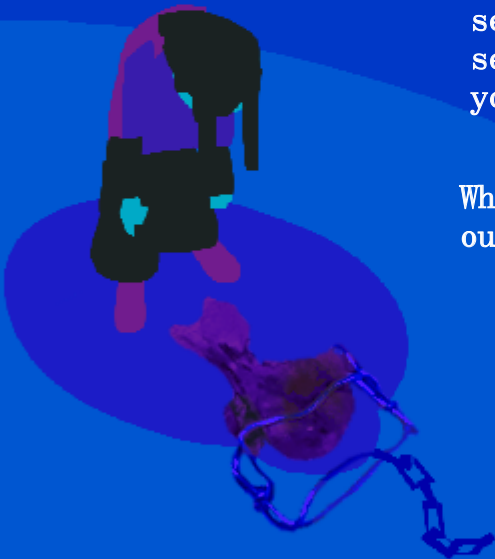
When he stands up, he places his foot on the outer wire of the trap and pulls.

The two sides squeeze together, slowly, and the metal grip loosens. The body between them is jostled, but not yet freed. Lynn does not watch.

He is sure that Cam has misunderstood something critical.

"What did you see?"

"What?"



Lynn shuts his mouth, smart enough not to repeat himself when prompted.

"What did I see," Cam says flatly.
"What did I see back there?"

He waves the gun in the general direction of the house. "You know, I actually can't believe you're asking me that."

"What is wrong with you that you need everyone to spell out even the most obvious shit to you all the time? Are you six? Are you stupid?"

He looks down at the half-open trap, bends down partway as if to return to it, and stops, straightening back out and focusing again on Lynn abruptly.

It is as if he can't help himself.

"Are you fucking with me?
Do you think I'm stupid?"





He takes the trap by the base of the chain, yanking it up from the ground and stomping over to Lynn.

He raises it with some effort and shakes it, body and all, in Lynn's face.

His breath is absurdly shallow.

"I'm not stupid," he says.



It hits the ground hard when he drops it,
unable to hold it so high for so long.

Lynn is looking at the bridge of his nose, the spaces between his teeth
and creases in his lips, anywhere but the dead thing.

"What did I see?" Cam repeats, mockingly. "What did I see? Don't be a fucking
idiot, Lynn, you were right there. You were more there than I was."

No wind passes through the clearing.
They are in total silence together.



Lynn sniffles audibly, wiping his nose,
and Cam's face contorts in a grimace.

"What," Lynn rasps after a prolonged moment.
"What, I'm sorry, I didn't know."



Cam looks up at him coldly.

"I didn't know," he insists again, a little louder.
"I never knew," His speech originates in the back of his mouth
and is inhibited by the front. "How was I supposed to know,
how was anyone...does Lori know?"



"I don't know what you're talking
about," is the curt response.
This, too, is genuine.

He does not wait for Lynn to look away first.
`He starts squeezing open the other half of the trap.

Lynn can't look away, afraid of the moment Cam remembers what he's holding and who he's with. The leaking mass in the trap is a blurred glob of color, no longer something to make visual sense of. He will get no answers from the body in front of him.

Cam lets go of the rope he's been pulling, lifts his foot from the trap and looks down at it. It's still closed firmly on its passenger.

Up close, the skin pinched up against the metal is so soft and wet as to have fused with it, yellow globules of lymph fluid having crusted in the space they connect. Were it alive and feeling, removing it from the trap would without doubt have been excruciating.

He makes no further effort to free the carcass.

The walk to the treeline is exceptionally brief and they emerge at the edge of the road a ways south of Markus' house.

It is an uneasy landmark even from a distance. Looking at it, Lynn is overcome by an immense and aimless gratitude. He is no longer in the house, he is no longer in the apartment, he is no longer in the house.





Cam is at his side, but if his head is at
Lynn's elbow or shoulder it is difficult to say.

He grew so much, so quickly, and only now does it
occur to Lynn that thoughts like these are more than
sentimentally voyeuristic. Like so many of his pleas and
apologies, they give context only to his own disconnect.

Ahead of Lynn by several feet, Cam walks with his eyes
straight and no curve of a slouch in his back.

The hole is gaping, but lately it gets
smaller every day. Something else, maybe,
to be concerned about.

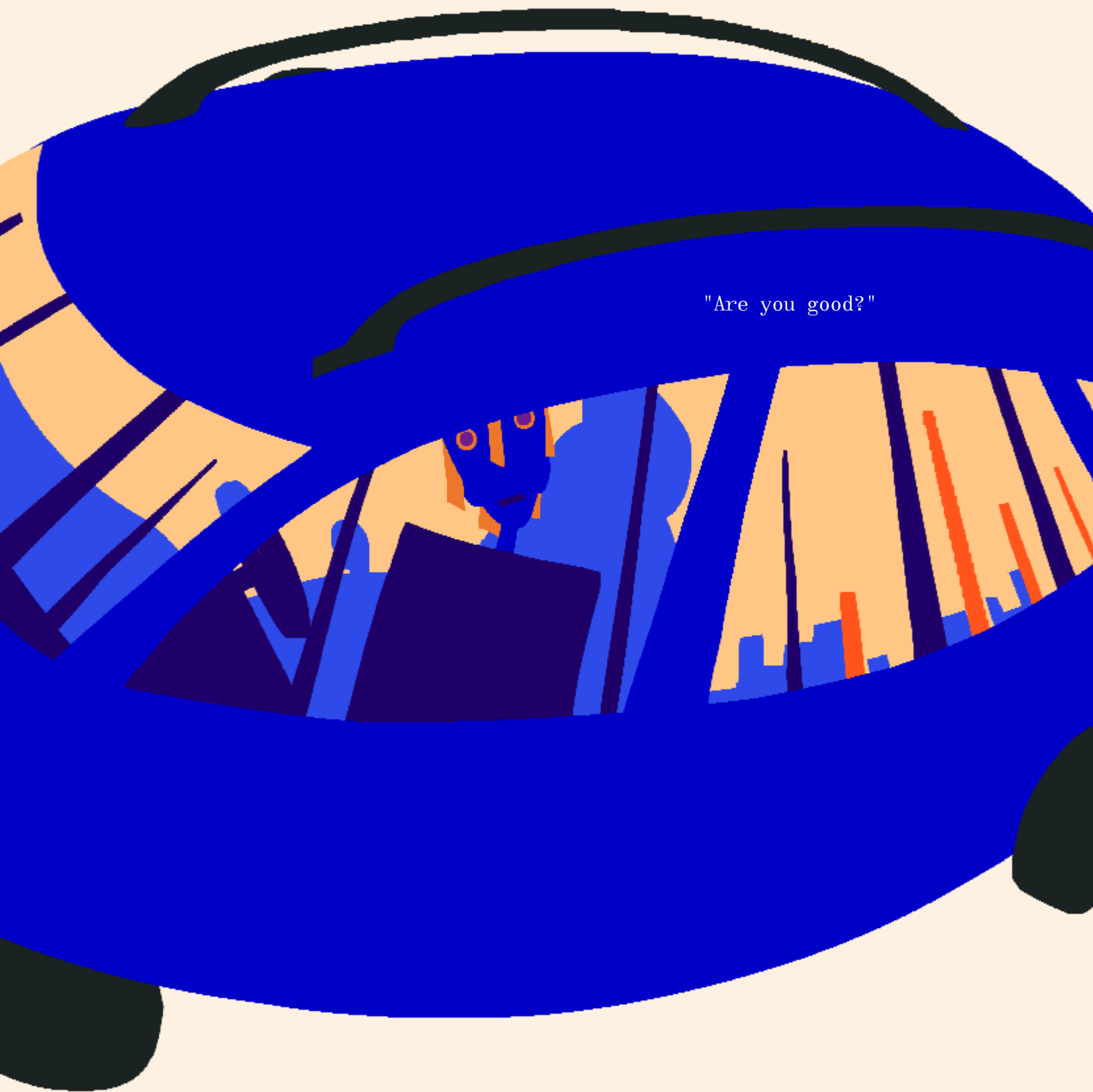
Lynn can still feel the heat
of the closet, the little hand
on his ankle. The memories
are disjointed, half-stitched
together with a careless
clumsiness reminiscent of
the vacations he'd spent in
Phoenix, dropping acid with
his friends.

It could have been 2001 or
2004 when Lynn had booked the
wrong hotel, when he'd been
tentatively involved with
Adrian or had run out of gas
on the drive back home.

They all bled into each other
in time. He can conjure no
evidence that everything he
recalls now didn't happen all
at once, on a single trip, or
never at all.

The memories of those nights are raucous
and warm, at odds with the present. The
mismatched dilutions and contractions,
though, are no longer without compare.

Himself presently unmoored from all context, Lynn stares at a car with a title in his name that he could have bought yesterday or never. His body opens the door, swings itself into the drivers' seat, and there is a feeling like unexpected stairs, or unexpected lack of stairs.



Hearing Cam's voice next to him in the passenger seat, he is fully convinced that the clarity and completeness of the sentence should shock him. The lack of a car seat certainly does.

He stares at the face across from him, and the pulsing bodies on the living room floor writhe again in the front of his mind. His stomach seizes but does not turn like it should when he dwells on the image, and he can't force it to.

Nothing about any part of this is right.

Cam grabs him by the wrist. "Are you good to drive or not?"

"Yes," he pants. He's suddenly aware of how dry his mouth is. When he tries to lick his lips, his tongue snags. "I'm fine, I just, I'm. I saw, in the house, it was - wasn't..."

"Can you get us home?" Cam presses, shaking Lynn's arm to keep his attention fixed.



For a moment, Lynn has the presence of mind to be slightly offended by the question.

Having developed a transparent fear of the new sky at night, Lynn has without conscious thought begun planning each day such that both he and Cam are home well before the sun sets. He flits around the house, closing the blinds at five in the afternoon, whispering apologies to Lori, prostrate and unresponsive on the couch.

He hadn't planned on returning to Markus' house this afternoon, and the road ahead of them is dark out now in spite of the white. The trees are striking, blackened against their new backing.

This is the latest Lynn has been out in more than a week, since the first days of the change.

The stark oddity of the sight washes over him without being absorbed in the slightest.

Having breached a ceiling in himself, he is freshly lacking a standard with which to measure his own dread.

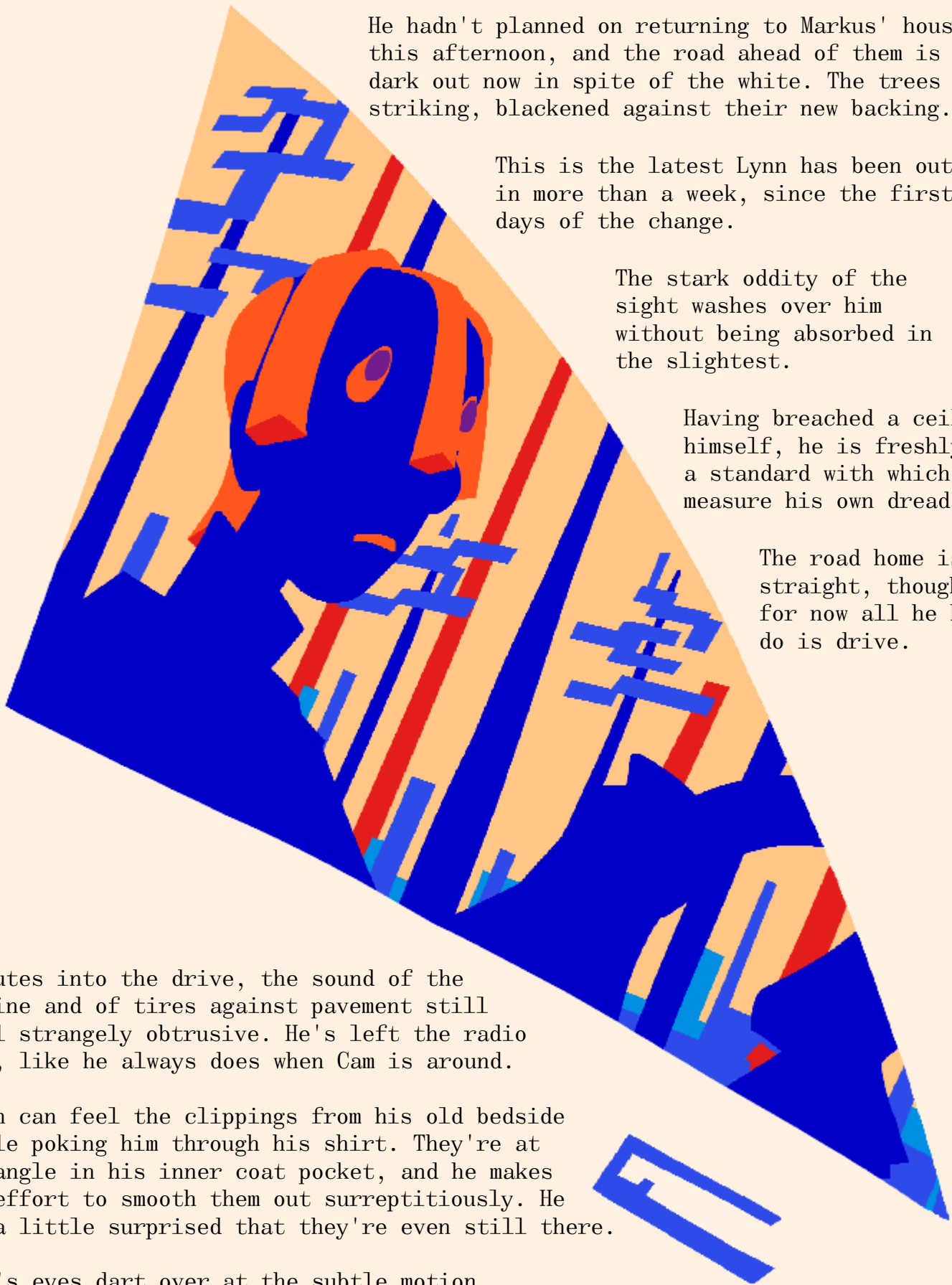
The road home is straight, though, and for now all he has to do is drive.

Minutes into the drive, the sound of the engine and of tires against pavement still feel strangely obtrusive. He's left the radio off, like he always does when Cam is around.

Lynn can feel the clippings from his old bedside table poking him through his shirt. They're at an angle in his inner coat pocket, and he makes an effort to smooth them out surreptitiously. He is a little surprised that they're even still there.

Cam's eyes dart over at the subtle motion. In the drivers' seat, Lynn can feel him staring even though he doesn't turn his head.

"What is it?" Cam shifts in his seat with deliberate casualness, still facing straight ahead.



Lynn doesn't say anything, doesn't look away from the road.

"Come on. It's not that big a deal, is it?"

Somewhat uncharacteristically, he pauses and actually waits for an answer. When he doesn't get one, he leans forward in his seat and reaches across the console.

He only barely tilts his head to get a visual on what he's doing, pulling the front of Lynn's coat open. Knocking Lynn's hand aside, he gets his fingers deep enough in the pocket to get a paper cut when Lynn slams on the brakes.



The tires of the car squeal audibly against the pavement, and Cam feels the seat belt dig into his collarbone with enough force to bruise. He is still speechless when they reach a complete stop, his arm pressed hard, thoughtlessly, across Lynn's chest as if to brace him for the sharp stop.



The hand in his coat pocket is a fist.

Lynn wrenches Cam's arm away with both hands, shoves him back across the center console and into his own seat.

When he sees that Cam is still holding the papers, he half-lunges for them and wrests them away; Cam offers no resistance.



Flushed in the face and gritting his teeth, Lynn does not bother struggling for words. "Stop!" he hisses. "Just stop!"

He tears the little stack in two and opens the door just wide enough to thrust his arm out, scattering pieces over the pavement. There are tears in his eyes.

Breathing hard, he looks over at Cam, who stares back at him without movement or expression.



Lynn takes a breath as if to speak and loses his patience prematurely, growling aloud in frustration.

Bristling in the drivers' seat, he lets off the brake in silence.

"What did you keep those around for?"

The car stops again, and Cam clicks his tongue sharply.

"Come on, man. You can't do this the whole ride home, someone's going to hit us. It's dark out, no one can see."

There's tension in his voice, but he speaks softly.

"They aren't looking. Half of them don't even turn on their headlights when it gets dark now. Come on, go."

It's not unlike talking to an animal. Cam's eyes roll back as the car rolls forward.

There is a lightness in his chest that he can't presently identify; his heart is racing.

The familiar age of waxy magazine paper between his fingers, having been crumpled and folded any number of passive little ways before being smoothed and pressed flat beneath a modest weight. He hadn't been able to stare long enough to read any of the text, but he hadn't needed to. Even the paperclip, he remembers.

Curiosity turns rancid in his chest. He can entertain his own questions only briefly before getting bored of them, having recently affirmed his suspicions beyond reasonable doubt.

The pleasure he takes in Lynn's discomfort (and by extension, Lynn himself) has long been contingent on that doubt, though, and without it, the man in the drivers' seat is as uninteresting as he would have to be for Cam to consider him a brother.

Settling more earnestly into his seat, Cam watches the endless flow of the roadside.

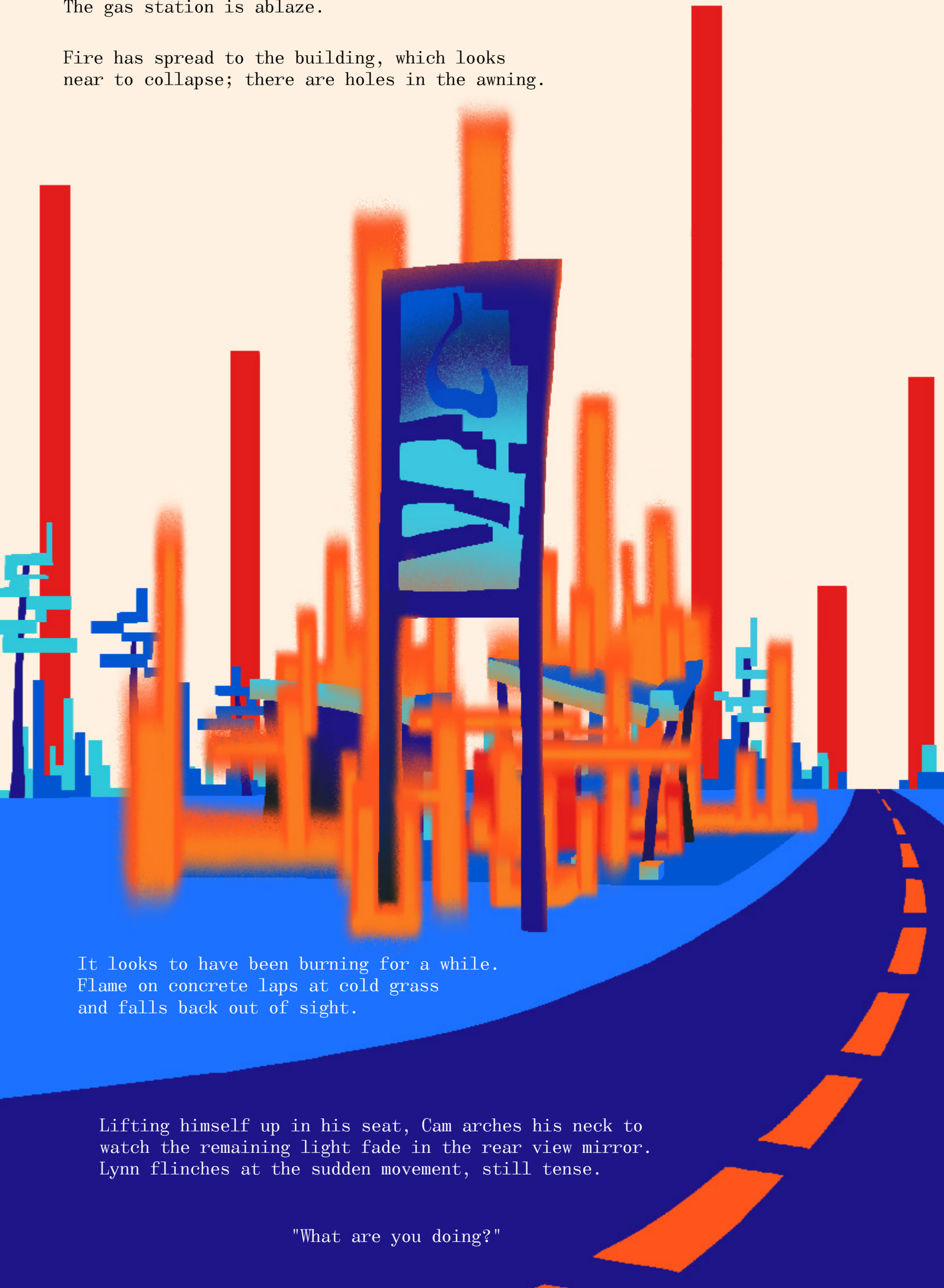
The outlines of treetops are so high he can't see them without pressing the side of his face flush to the window, and everything beneath them is too dark to see.

They're going faster than usual. He doesn't look over at the speedometer. If Lynn has decided, in being found out, to kill them both, then they both will die. It seems unlikely, though.

The sparse ground of a clearing to the right of the car is lit yellow, visible only for an instant before a flash of orange. Cam swivels in his seat as they go by, trying to keep his eyes on it.

The gas station is ablaze.

Fire has spread to the building, which looks
near to collapse; there are holes in the awning.

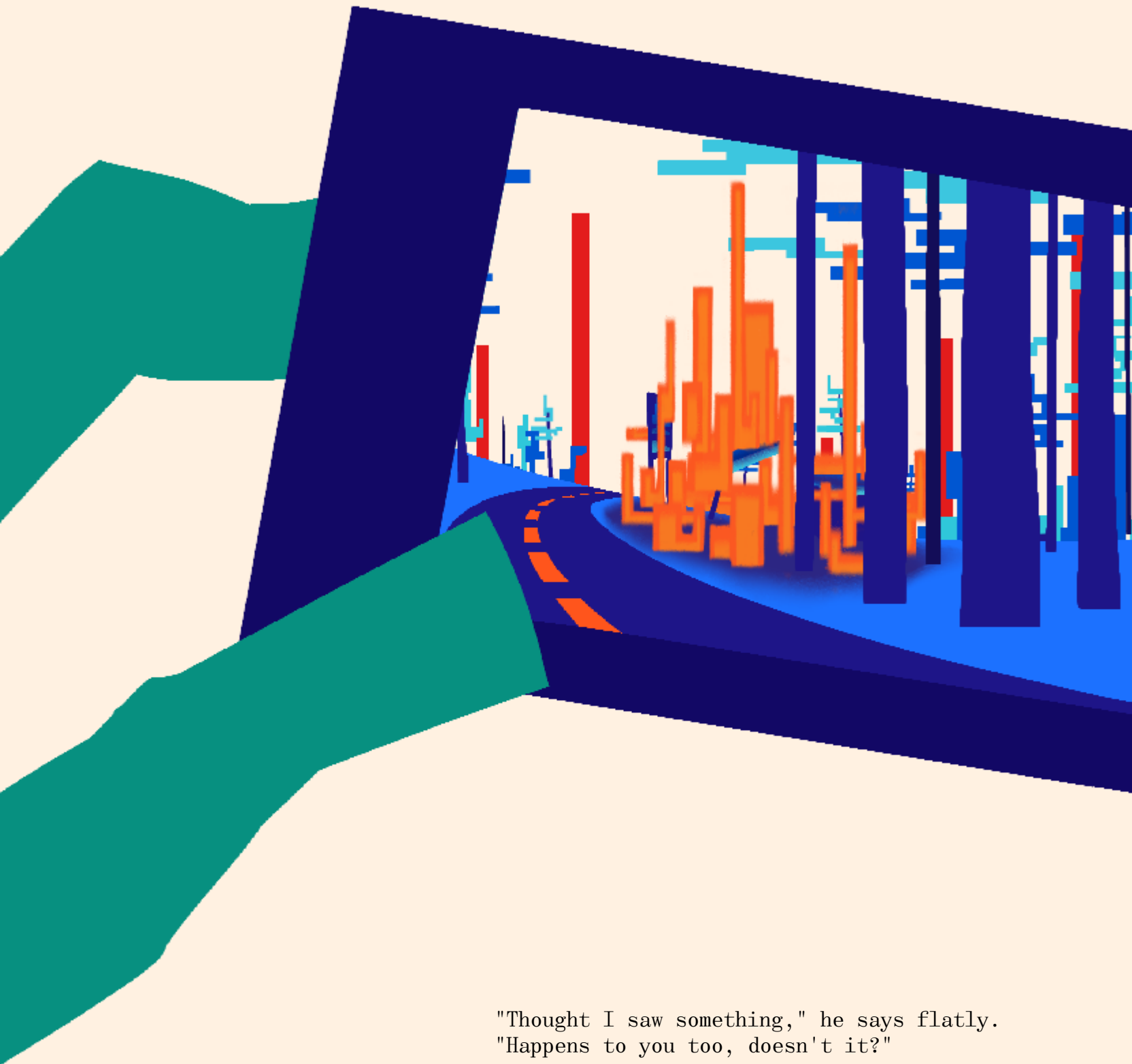


It looks to have been burning for a while.
Flame on concrete laps at cold grass
and falls back out of sight.

Lifting himself up in his seat, Cam arches his neck to
watch the remaining light fade in the rear view mirror.
Lynn flinches at the sudden movement, still tense.

"What are you doing?"

Cam sits back down, reaches up and tweaks the mirror towards himself. He keeps his hand on the mirror until the remains of the gas station on the horizon have dimmed.



"Thought I saw something," he says flatly.
"Happens to you too, doesn't it?"